



SCARS OF THE HORIZON

Kenshi 1.0.68

Modlist & Guide

Version 1.0.68 - 2026

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Installation Guide

This chapter takes you from a fresh Kenshi install to a running, verified modded setup: the exact game build, the mod manager, where every mod in this guide comes from, and the load order the whole guide assumes. It is written against **Kenshi 1.0.68** (released April 1, 2024) and against **KMM — Kenshi Mod Manager** (Nexus mod 1765), which the project’s verification (Task 3) judged COMPATIBLE with that build. Every claim in this chapter was checked against that verification before it was written; where a detail could not be confirmed, the chapter says so instead of guessing. If you are following the waves in order, you do the setup here exactly once, up front. Each wave then adds its own content on top of the base you build now, and the final section of this chapter explains how to switch between waves without rebuilding anything.

The whole chapter, in one glance:

1. **Game prep** — Kenshi 1.0.68 from Steam, confirmed and pinned.
2. **Install KMM** — the mod manager (Nexus 1765), extracted and run.
3. **Point KMM at the game** — the Steam path resolves.
4. **Fetch the mods** — Workshop subscribes plus the four Nexus downloads.
5. **Load order** — the canonical ordering every wave follows.
6. **Launch & verify** — the launcher’s Mods tab shows everything loading.
7. **Per-wave switching** — the playset discipline that keeps waves scoped.

Each step is one short section below. None of them should take more than a few minutes, and the order they are written in is the order you should do them — the load order section depends on the mods being fetched, which depends on KMM being pointed at the game, which depends on the game being prepped.

Game Prep

Start with a clean, current Kenshi from Steam. Steam is the primary mod source for this guide — nearly every mod in the list is subscribed from the Steam Workshop — so install the game through Steam and let it fully download before you touch anything else. Run the game once to generate its install-folder files and confirm it launches; that first run also proves which build you actually have before anything else gets layered on top. (KMM itself works with both the Steam and GOG versions of Kenshi, but the guide assumes Steam because that is where its mods live.)

The build matters. This guide targets **1.0.68**, the version released on **April 1, 2024** — that is the exact build every mod in this list was verified against, and the build every fact in the wave chapters was checked against. Confirm your install is at that build before you begin, and once it is, tell Steam not to update Kenshi automatically. Every mod card in this guide was checked against 1.0.68, and keeping the game pinned to that build is what makes the rest of the guide’s claims hold.

Warning: If Kenshi auto-updates off 1.0.68 later, re-confirm the build before continuing. The mods in this list were verified against 1.0.68 specifically; a different build is outside this guide’s guarantees. After you have confirmed the version once, disable automatic updates for Kenshi in Steam so it stays there.

Kenshi keeps its mod data in its install folder and its Workshop downloads in Steam’s own workshop folders, so there is nothing else to install for the game itself. Kenshi’s launcher carries a **Mods** tab (its built-in mod manager) that lists every installed mod and the load order the game will use — it is the ground truth of what the game will actually load, and every verification step in this chapter points at it. With a clean 1.0.68 confirmed and pinned, the next step is the mod manager.

A note for the GOG alternative: KMM’s requirements list “Kenshi (Steam or GOG version)”, so GOG owners can use it too. But this guide’s mod list is built around Steam — the primary source for the list

is the Steam Workshop, and the Wave o base includes Workshop-published texture and performance mods that are most simply subscribed there. If you play on GOG, you would be downloading the Workshop-only mods from their Nexus mirrors or manual files instead, which is doable but outside the steps written here; this chapter assumes Steam.

Install KMM (Nexus Mod 1765)

The mod manager for this guide is **KMM — Kenshi Mod Manager**, by Aze4ka, on Nexus Mods:

- Mod: **KMM - Kenshi Mod Manager** (Nexus mod 1765)
- Source code: github.com/nonniks/KenshiModManager
- First uploaded 2025-10-12; last updated 2025-10-19; current release **v1.0.0**.

Its requirements, as listed on the mod page: **Windows 10+ (64-bit), Kenshi (Steam or GOG version)**, and — importantly for a smooth install — it is **self-contained**, so it needs **no separate .NET install** and no other runtime. Download the archive from the mod page, extract it to a folder you can keep (anywhere outside the game folder works; KMM does not need to live inside Kenshi), and run the executable it contains.

Warning: Grab the **current** KMM — Aze4ka’s, released October 2025. The Nexus ID 1765 previously pointed to a different, older “Kenshi Mod Manager” by MillerScout, and the two are separate projects. The verification behind this guide (and every instruction that follows) applies to the current holder of Nexus 1765: Aze4ka’s KMM, version 1.0.0.

KMM’s verified feature list is what the rest of this chapter builds on: it **automatically finds Kenshi and Steam installation paths**; it manages load order by **drag & drop reordering** (its own usage text: “Drag mods to reorder load priority”); it keeps **playsets**, each saved as its own separate .cfg file; it offers **Save & Launch** — which applies your changes and starts Kenshi; and it detects **Steam, local, and custom** mod sources. All of those features are confirmed in the project’s GitHub README and Nexus description, and every step below uses only them.

One honesty note before you start clicking. The compatibility verdict behind this chapter is COMPATIBLE, but it rests on the evidence the verification could actually reach: KMM is actively maintained (last updated 2025-10-19, well after 1.0.68), its requirements pin no specific Kenshi version, and no breakage reports were found in its sources. What could **not** be obtained is an explicit community confirmation of running KMM under 1.0.68 — the Nexus comment threads are rendered by JavaScript and could not be fetched for verification. That is a hole in the evidence, not a reason to avoid KMM; the verdict stands, but treat the first launched game in this chapter as the real confirmation. Everything this guide needs from KMM — playsets, drag & drop ordering, Steam detection, Save & Launch — is documented by the tool itself.

Point KMM at Your Game

KMM’s first and most useful feature is that it **automatically finds Kenshi and Steam installation paths** — this is stated in its GitHub README and is the intended first-run behaviour. When you start KMM, let it detect the install, and then confirm that the path it resolved points at your real Kenshi installation (the folder that contains the game’s executable and its data folder).

If your setup is not found automatically — for example, if Kenshi lives in a non-standard Steam library location or on a different drive — you can point KMM at the game yourself. The exact wording of the control for this may vary by KMM version, so do not hunt for a specific label: the intent is simply **make KMM load the order from your Kenshi install and let it see the mod folders in that install**. KMM does not document the mechanism it uses to detect Steam paths (registry lookup versus library scan is unconfirmed), so a manual pointer is the reliable fallback whenever automatic detection fails.

Tip: After pointing KMM at the game, launch Kenshi once through KMM before installing any mods (its Save & Launch button applies changes and starts the game). If the game opens normally, KMM has the right install. If it does not, re-check the path — an unverified path will only cause confusing problems later, after mods are already on top of it.

Fetch the Mods

Every mod in this guide comes from one of two places: **Steam Workshop** (primary) or **Nexus Mods** (secondary). The split is recorded per mod in its card in the wave chapters — each card's URL is the verified source, and the verification method for each is logged in the project's STATUS file.

For the Workshop mods, subscribe to each one on its Steam page. Steam downloads the files itself, and because KMM detects Steam mod sources, the subscribed mods appear in KMM automatically once the game's Workshop content is in place. For the Nexus mods, download the archive from Nexus and make it available to KMM through its local/custom mod detection; the exact import flow for a local mod may vary by KMM version, but the intent is always the same — the mod ends up inside Kenshi's mod data, where the game (and KMM) can see it. If a mod is available on both Workshop and Nexus, prefer the Workshop copy: it is the primary source for this list, updates through Steam automatically, and keeps the game's own workshop handling in charge.

Most of the list is Workshop. The mods whose primary source is Nexus are the four whose cards list a Nexus URL: **Particle System Override**, **Kenshi Performance Fix**, and **Kenshi CTD fix patch** (Wave 0), and **Shek Perfect Body** (Wave 1). A few Workshop mods also have official Nexus mirrors, but subscribing from the Workshop is enough for those — the mirror is an alternative, not a requirement. Each wave's Modlist section lists its exact URLs, so fetch the mods wave by wave as you reach that wave, exactly as the per-wave switching section describes below.

Load Order

Kenshi's load-order system is the one thing that decides whether the mods in this guide work together, so it is worth being precise. The rule, verified against both a Steam community guide and the Kenshi wiki FAQ:

> **Later in the list = higher priority.** Mods lower in the order overwrite mods higher in the order; “the mod loaded AFTER, will override the value above it.”

What that means in practice: when two mods edit the same game value, the one that loads later wins — its version is the one the game keeps. That is why the ordering discipline in this guide exists at all. A texture mod loaded too late can silently override another texture mod's work; a faction mod loaded too early can have its new gear wiped by a later overhaul; a patch mod loaded before the mod it patches does nothing at all. Kenshi gives the community no automated conflict resolution — the wiki is explicit that users are responsible for load order, either by trial and error or by following author recommendations — so the whole guide's ordering rules exist to prevent that silent churn before you ever see it in game.

Tip: When a mod card in a wave chapter says “author instruction” about load order, it is quoting a requirement straight from that mod's page — Slopeless above Forgotten Buildings, Dwarven Weapons behind the GUI/texture/weather mods, Shiny Plate Armor last except GUI, the CTD fix patch at the very end. Those are the rules the authors themselves set, and they outrank any general guideline in this chapter.

The load order is stored in `mods.cfg` in the game's data folder. KMM's drag & drop reordering is the tool you use to arrange it; its playsets are saved as separate `.cfg` files. One caveat the verification flagged honestly: KMM's documentation does not confirm whether it writes the game's {Kenshi}/

data/mods.cfg directly, and it does not document whether its drag & drop direction (top of the list = first-loaded) matches Kenshi's "later = higher priority" exactly. The robust way to use KMM regardless of that uncertainty is to arrange the list so that the mod that must **win** a conflict sits **later** in the order, then confirm the result in the game itself — Kenshi's own Mods menu shows the order the game will actually load, and that is the source of truth.

The canonical ordering this guide follows is **base fixes and QoL first, content after**. Because the waves are cumulative (see Per-Wave Switching), the ordering below is the full shape of the list once every wave is installed; each wave's Modlist section restates the parts of it that matter at that point. Read it top to bottom as **earliest loaded → latest loaded**:

- **Compressed Textures Project** (Wave 0) — the very top of every setup. Its author instructs that it loads above all other mods, and every later wave's install order repeats that instruction so textures render correctly.
- **Base fixes and QoL** (Wave 0) — the performance and readability stack: **Dark UI**, **Nice Map**, **Particle System Override**, **Kenshi Performance Fix**. **Dark UI** and **Nice Map** are pure texture swaps, safe anywhere above content; **Expanded Craftable Weapons** (Wave 2) lists **Dark UI** as a dependency and needs it above.
- **Weather and visual pairs — Mood Weather** (Wave 1) pairs with **Particle System Override** (Wave 0); **Biome Edits** (Wave 3) is by the same author as **Mood Weather** and pairs with it, so keep the two near each other.
- **Map-layer mods together — Accurate Zones Patch** (Wave 3) edits the zone-border map texture and sits with the map-layer mods, independent of **Nice Map** (the GUI map) and **Biome Edits** (the terrain textures), so all three can load together.
- **Wave 1 content** — the settlement layer. Author-required order: **Slopeless** must sit **above Forgotten Buildings** (wrong order blocks placement of some buildings); **Mood Weather** already sits in the visual zone above. Do **not** run **Fish and Meat Industry** alongside its superseded sibling **Meat Production and Processing**.
- **Wave 2 content** — the forge. **Shiny Plate Armor** loads last except for GUI mods (author instruction — it touches many vanilla files); do **not** run **Radiant Vanilla Reborn Weapons** alongside **Radiant Asamarume Weapons** (they are already integrated in that mod's version 2.0); **Industrial Expansion** pairs with the vanilla research tree rather than replacing it.
- **Wave 3 content** — the expedition. **Dwarven Weapons** loads behind the GUI, texture and weather mods (author instruction); **Small Caravans** changes nothing in the base game and slots anywhere; the camping pair (**Sensible Nomadism - A Camping Overhaul + Tents**) stacks rather than conflicts.
- **Wave 4 content** — the conquest. **Reactive World** sits with the large overhauls, ahead of the small faction additions; **Cannibals Expanded** and **Shrieking Bandits Expanded** sit **below Reactive World** so their new equipment applies to the reworked factions; the **Reactive World + RP fCats - Patch** sits directly above **Recruit Prisoners for Cats**; do **not** run **Recruit Prisoners for Cats** alongside the original **Recruit Prisoners**.
- **Kenshi CTD fix patch** (Wave 0) — last of all. It auto-generates a patch mod that must sit at the very end of the load order.

Tip: If a mod's changes are not showing up in-game, the fix is almost always load order: move that mod **later** in the list so it loads after the mod it is conflicting with. Kenshi's rule is later = higher priority, so a mod that is being overwritten simply needs to move down the order. Check the launcher's Mods tab after every reorder to see what actually loaded.

Each wave's Modlist section restates its own install order at the point where that wave is reached; the list above is the shape of the whole thing so you can see how the layers fit.

Launch & Verify

Once the mods for the active wave are fetched and ordered, start the game with KMM's **Save & Launch** — it applies your changes and launches Kenshi. Then verify that the load actually worked:

1. In Kenshi's launcher, open the **Mods** tab. It lists every installed mod and the order the game will load them — this is the authoritative view, not KMM's list.
2. Confirm every mod you enabled for this wave is present in that list, and that the order matches the canonical ordering above (top = the **Compressed Textures Project**, bottom = **Kenshi CTD fix patch**).
3. Confirm none of them reports a load problem. Every Kenshi mod is identified by its .mod file, so a mod whose files did not install correctly — a missing or misplaced .mod file — will not load, and the Mods tab is where that failure shows up.
4. Start a new game and play the first minutes of the wave's opening to confirm the mods behave before committing to the run. A wave's mechanics mods (farming, crafting, camping) are best confirmed by actually using them, not just by checking the list.

Warning: A mod that fails to load almost always means its files did not land where Kenshi expects them — not that the mod is broken. If the Mods tab flags one, re-fetch that single mod (re-subscribe on the Workshop, or re-download from Nexus), make sure its files are intact, and re-check. Verify every enabled mod loads cleanly **before** you invest hours in a new game, because the .mod failure is the one load-order error that cannot be fixed from inside a save.

If the game starts and every enabled mod appears in the Mods tab with no load errors, the setup is done and you are ready for the wave you started.

Per-Wave Switching

The waves of this guide are one campaign played in order, and the mods you install are **cumulative**: Wave 0's six base mods (the UI, map, texture and performance stack) stay active in every wave, and each wave adds its own content on top of that foundation. The wave chapters confirm this continuously — **Expanded Craftable Weapons** (Wave 2) requires **Dark UI** (Wave 0); **Biome Edits** (Wave 3) pairs with **Mood Weather** (Wave 1); the Wave 3 expedition uses the portable turret kit from Wave 2; the Wave 4 defence doctrine assumes the Wave 2 crossbow turrets. So you never **remove** earlier mods; you **add** each wave's mods when you reach that wave.

"Enabling only the active wave's mods" means keeping the enabled set scoped to where you are in the campaign — the Wave 0 base plus the content of every wave you have reached, and nothing from the waves you have not. A Wave 0 fresh game should not carry Wave 4's faction overhauls; a Wave 2 game should not yet have Wave 3's expedition mods. In practice, switching waves means three things:

1. **Fetch the new wave's mods** (subscribe on the Workshop / download from Nexus) so they are available to KMM.
2. **Arrange them into the load order** using the canonical shape above — the new wave's content slots in below the Wave 0 base, under its own wave's ordering rules.
3. **Start the wave's setup** — continue the same save where the waves are sequential, or start (or import into) a new game for that wave's fresh start, then verify in the launcher's Mods tab that the active wave's mods all load.

Because KMM saves each playset as its own .cfg file, the cleanest way to manage this is to **save a playset at the end of each wave** — one for the base setup, one with each wave's content added —

so switching between setups is a matter of loading the saved playset instead of re-arranging the list by hand.

Tip: Save a KMM playset after every wave's setup is verified. Name it for the wave ("Wave 0", "Wave 1", ...), and you have a one-click state for the whole campaign: start a new game from the playset for the wave you are on, and you can always return to the exact verified state of an earlier wave. The playset is the wave-switching mechanism KMM itself provides, so use it instead of re-ordering the list by hand.

With the game at 1.0.68, KMM pointed at it, the mods fetched, ordered and verified, and a playset saved per wave, the installation is complete. The next chapter opens the campaign itself.

Waves & New-Game Setups

Wave 0: The Wanderer

The Wanderer: How to Play

You wake in The Hub — a ruined crossroads town in the Border Zone, an outlaw settlement that the Holy Nation, the Shek Kingdom and everyone else abandoned long ago. You have a name, a set of clothes, and no memory of how you got here. What happens next is entirely up to you. This chapter teaches the fundamentals every wanderer needs: how to control the camera and your character, how to read the interface, what your stats and health actually mean, and — because Kenshi will knock you down sooner or later — what happens when you lose. It closes with the survival loop that will carry you through your first week.

Everything here describes vanilla Kenshi 1.0.68. Wave 0 installs no content mods; the six mods in the Modlist section only make the game easier to see and smoother to run.

Controls & Keybindings

Kenshi is an RTS-style game on the surface and a survival RPG underneath: you steer a camera, click to command, and your characters act on their own between orders. The defaults below are what Kenshi 1.0.68 ships with, and every one of them can be remapped under **Options** → **Controls**.

Tip: Pause is your best friend. Kenshi keeps running while you think — reading stats, sorting loot and planning a retreat all happen while the game is paused. Make pressing the spacebar a habit from minute one.

Category	Action	Input
Camera	Move the camera	WASD / Arrow keys / mouse to screen edge
Camera	Rotate the camera	Hold middle mouse + drag, or Q / E
Camera	Free look	Hold Left Ctrl + move mouse
Camera	Zoom in / out	Mouse wheel
Selection	Select a character	Left-click the character or their portrait
Selection	Add to the selection	Shift + left-click
Selection	Box-select many	Left-drag a box over them
Selection	Select the whole squad	~ key (the grave accent key, above Tab)
Commands	Move / walk to a spot	Right-click the ground
Commands	Open the action menu	Hold right-click on a person or building
Commands	Default action	Right-click the target — attack enemies, talk to allies
Game	Pause / unpause	Spacebar
Game	Normal / 2x / 5x speed	F2 / F3 / F4
Menus	Character stats	C
Menus	Inventory	I
Menus	World map	M
Menus	Technology / research	T
Menus	Crafting queue	Y
Squad	Cycle between squads	Tab
Squad	Jump to character 1-0	Number row; press the key twice to focus the camera
Misc	Quick save / quick load	F5 / F9
Misc	Highlight loot / allow stealing	Left Alt

Misc	Hide the UI / screenshot	F7 / F8
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The mouse does most of the work. **Right-click on the ground** tells your selected characters to move there; **right-click directly on a person** performs the default action — attack if they are hostile, talk if they are friendly. **Hold right-click** on anything to open the contextual action menu (Trade, First Aid, Attack, and so on). If you ever feel lost behind the interface, press **F7** to hide it and **F8** to capture the moment.

Warning: The camera rotates around a fixed point and the zoom range is limited in vanilla. Don't fight it — drag with the middle mouse button and use the mouse wheel, and if the camera ever feels stuck, double-press the number of the selected character to snap focus back onto them.

The Interface Tour

The whole HUD is built around a few panels, and once you know what each one tells you, the game opens up.

- **Squad panel (bottom of the screen):** one portrait per character, each with their health bars beneath it. Click a portrait to select that character; **right-click** it to centre the camera on them. This is where your whole crew lives, and it is the first thing you look at when a fight starts.
- **Selected character panel (bottom-left):** the detailed sheet for whoever is selected. It shows their body part health — Head, Chest, Stomach, and the four limbs — plus blood, hunger, the KO point, their current action, and how encumbered they are. Expanding it with the chevron shows the full stat list.
- **Speed and pause controls (bottom-right):** the F2/F3/F4 speed buttons and the pause toggle. Everything in Kenshi obeys game speed, including wounds and hunger, so dropping to pause or 1x during a bad fight is a legitimate tactic.
- **World map (M):** shows the continent, your position, and — if you installed **Nice Map** — zone names, roads and borders. Cities appear as they are discovered; the map does not reveal them for free.
- **Character stats (C):** the left column is attributes (Strength, Toughness, Dexterity...), the right column is skills (Melee Attack, Labouring, Field Medic...). Skills are capped at 100, but the game never stops training them.
- **Inventory (I):** your equipment slots, backpack, and everything you carry. Items have weight; the heavier you are, the slower you walk.
- **The selection ring:** a coloured circle under your selected character in the world. Hostile characters show a red ring when targeted; friendly characters show green. Colours on the selection ring and in the squad panel tell you faction standing at a glance.

Tip: Use the map to check where your character is standing before you wander off. The Hub sits near the centre of the Border Zone — west is Squin and the Shek Kingdom, east leads deeper into Holy Nation territory, and the deadlands around the old cities are no place for a beginner.

The World Around The Hub

The Border Zone is an arid no-man's-land wedged between two powers — the Holy Nation to the east and the Shek Kingdom to the west — and abandoned by both. The Hub itself is a ruined outlaw town: built by the Holy Nation, razed by the Shek, and left for whoever dares to squat in the ruins. That history shapes everything you meet out here.

Who you will actually encounter in your first week:

- **Starving bandits** — starving civilians turned to banditry, the weakest regular threat in the zone. They come in packs of weak, half-starved fighters, and they are your training dummies. They will beat you up, loot you, and leave you — the classic first-fight loss.
- **Dust bandits** — better armed, better trained, and their fortified bases dot the region. They hit harder and chase further. Do not pick this fight until you have a companion or a wall.
- **Black Dragon Ninjas** — a tougher bandit faction with a base somewhere in the zone. They are the reason the deeper reaches are not for beginners.
- **Tech Hunters** — wanderers hunting the ruins of the ancients. They are neutral and will not bother you; some of them trade, and their camps are safe enough to rest near.
- **Holy Nation Outlaws** — the zone's human outcasts, which is what the population of The Hub mostly is. The Hub's bar is run by Trade Ninjas, and a Shinobi Thieves watchtower stands at one end of town — useful places to know.

The region is sparse on patrols, which is why the bandits flourish here and why you must be your own guard. But the same lawlessness that breeds bandits breeds opportunity: the zone has high-quality copper and iron veins near its towns and merchants, which is exactly why the mining economy works so well here.

Warning: Faction standing is worth reading. The red ring around a targeted hostile and the colours in the squad panel tell you who will attack on sight. In the Border Zone the map is not the danger — the people on it are. Learn to read the rings before you leave the gates.

Your Character: Stats, Health, Hunger

Kenshi has no character levels and no XP for kills. Every stat grows only through use — run to raise Athletics, swing a blade to raise Melee Attack, get hit to raise Toughness. Your character sheet (C) is a report card of everything you have done so far.

Which four stats matter most early:

- **Strength** — determines your carry weight, your damage with blunt weapons and martial arts, and how fast you swing heavy weapons. You train it by carrying heavy loads and fighting. A strong character can haul a mining haul and outpace the bandits chasing them.
- **Toughness** — your damage resistance and your ability to shrug off knock-outs. It trains by taking hits and, crucially, by **getting back up** after being beaten down instead of playing dead. Early on, Toughness is the difference between a scrape and a body.
- **Dexterity** — governs how fast you attack with a weapon. It trains with cut-damage weapons, so cheap sabres and katanas are its natural teachers.
- **Melee Attack** — your chance to win the attack turn against an opponent and to land hits past their **Melee Defense**. For a lone wanderer it is the stat that decides whether you kill the starving bandit or he kills you.

Tip: Strength is the easiest stat to train safely: load up a backpack with copper or iron ore and walk. The more you carry, the slower you move — and the harder Strength trains — just don't do it while enemies are chasing you.

Health. Every body part has its own health pool, and damage is localised. A wound to the leg slows you; a wound to the arm weakens your grip. The three **vitals** — Head, Chest and Stomach — decide life and death: drop below 0 and you fall unconscious; drop below -100% of their maximum and you die outright. The blood bar sits above the body parts: little arrows over the blood mean you are bleeding out, and the more arrows, the faster. Bandages stop bleeding and mend cut damage; a bed or camp bed multiplies healing eight or four times over.

Hunger. Food fills the hunger bar, and characters eat automatically when it drops below 250 — the lowest-nutrition food they carry first, up to 50 nutrition per bite. Let hunger fall below 200 and malnutrition starts dragging your stats down; below about 100 you begin fainting, and sustained starvation kills. Food carried in any squad member's backpack is shared, so one person can carry bread for everyone. Skeletons do not eat at all.

Warning: Check the blood line after every fight. A character who survives the combat with 1 health can still bleed out on the walk home. Bandage first, loot second — corpses are not going anywhere.

Encumbrance and Carrying

Everything you carry weighs something, and Kenshi tracks it as **encumbrance** — your carried weight measured against your Strength. The heavier you are relative to your Strength, the more the world charges you for it:

- **Movement speed:** drops 1% for every 1% of encumbrance, maxing out at a crawl when you are at 100% encumbrance.
- **Combat speed:** drops too, though more gently (about 0.235% per 1% encumbrance, up to a quarter lost at 100%).
- **Dodge and Martial Arts:** both fall as you get heavier — dodge by 1% per 1% encumbrance (capped at a -60% dodge around 60% encumbrance) and martial arts by 0.8% per 1%.
- **Hunger:** burns faster the more you haul — hunger rate rises 0.007 per 1% of encumbrance, so an overloaded character empties the food pack faster.

The inventory screen shows your current weight and your encumbrance percentage, and how much of it comes from what you are carrying. Two practical rules come out of it: **stay under roughly half your carry capacity when travelling**, and remember that what hangs on your back — and in a backpack — counts just like what you hold in your hands. That is why the mining tip works: a full backpack of copper trains your Strength while it slows you, and when you drop it at the trader you become fast again.

Tip: Encumbrance is the flip side of Strength training. Load up heavy, walk, and you will see Strength climb — then drop the load and enjoy the speed again. This loop of “load, walk, unload, run” is the standard early way to raise Strength without ever swinging a sword.

Combat Basics

Kenshi fights in attack turns rather than real-time button mashing. When two characters meet, the one with the better **Melee Attack** relative to the opponent's **Melee Defense** takes more turns: each point of attack advantage shifts the odds of being the attacker by roughly 2.5%, and a large advantage means you attack twice for every one of theirs. Attack also beats defense for landing hits — your attack skill lowers their chance to block, and a big skill gap turns a fight into a one-sided beating.

Every attack is either **blocked**, **dodged**, or **landed**:

- A **block** stops the damage entirely but uses up the defender's turn — this is how defense works: the more defense you have, the more often you trade their attack for nothing.
- A **dodge** also avoids the hit, and some weapons swing wide enough that they are harder to avoid.
- A **landed** hit deals **cut** damage (which bleeds and can sever limbs) and **blunt** damage (which breaks bones and knocks people out). Armour resists these differently, which is why a beat-up samurai in plate is a wall and a naked recruit is a pincushion.

Stagger. Powerful or heavy hits can stagger an opponent, interrupting their next attack and stealing their turn. This is why a big, slow two-handed weapon is deadly against light, fast enemies — when it lands, it lands hard enough to stop them answering.

What happens when you lose. It depends on who beats you and where:

- **Knock-out:** when a vital part drops below 0 you fall unconscious. Bandits will typically loot you and leave you in the dirt; slavers will carry you off.
- **Recovery coma:** if your injuries go deep enough, you enter a coma until your vitals rise above 0 again. A companion (or a passing stranger, if you are lucky) can patch you up with First Aid; a bed finishes the job. Unbandaged cuts keep bleeding while you lie there.
- **Death:** if Head, Chest or Stomach goes below -100% of its maximum, you die — the character is gone from the world for good.
- **Slavery:** fall near the slavers of the United Cities or the Reavers, and you may wake up in a cage, sold into bondage. You can work your way free, escape, or wait to be rescued; escaped slaves sometimes choose to join you.

Warning: In the first week, do not fight fair fights. Starving bandits come in groups, dust bandits hit harder, and dogs eat the dead. Use the town gates, use the bar's patrons, use numbers — and use your legs. Retreating is winning.

Weapons and Armour

A wanderer is only as good as their gear, so learn to read it before you buy it. Every character has two weapon slots: **Weapon I** (the primary) and **Weapon II** (a secondary that most weapons can't fit — only compact blades like sabres and katanas go there). Characters use the primary weapon in most fights, and the secondary when the primary is not usable, such as when an arm is injured. Equipping a weapon also stacks its stat bonuses and penalties only while it is the active weapon.

Weapon damage is split two ways — cut and blunt — and every weapon does some mix of both:

- **Cut damage** is the blade's work: it bleeds and can sever limbs. Katanas and sabres are almost pure cut, which is why they train **Dexterity** well — Dexterity gains track how much of a weapon's damage is cut.
- **Blunt damage** is the hammer's work: it breaks bones and knocks people out. Clubs, jittes and heavy weapons lean blunt, and they hit hard against armour.

Weapon quality matters more than the name on the hilt. Weapons come in grades from Rusted Junk up through better manufacturing, and quality raises damage, bonuses, and sometimes penalties. A Rusted Junk sword is the classic “penny for every rusty piece of crap sword” item — but it has a hidden use: because it subtracts a little from your attack and defense, it makes fights **harder**, which trains your combat stats faster. Low-grade weapons also carry proportionally more cut damage, so a Rusted Junk sabre is the standard training weapon.

Armour comes in three weight classes, each trading protection for mobility:

- **Light armour** — the wanderer's default. Cheap, light, almost no skill penalties, but offers little protection. Fine for early mining runs and safe fights.
- **Medium armour** — more coverage than light and less resistance than heavy, without heavy's severe penalties. The sensible upgrade when you can afford it.
- **Heavy armour** — the most protection in the game, and it drags your stats down with it: Dexterity and other combat stats take penalties, and the extra weight and sluggishness make every fight harder. That difficulty has an upside — the harder the fight, the faster your stats train — which is why heavies are the tanks of Kenshi.

Tip: Don't buy the best weapon you can afford at The Hub; buy the **trainer**. A cheap Rusted Junk sabre trains Dexterity fast and makes you grind Melee Attack and Defense harder. Save the expensive edge weapons for when your stats are already high enough to deserve them.

First Aid and Medicine

Every wound in Kenshi is a job to be done, and the two kinds of damage demand two kinds of care:

- **Cut damage** — the bleeders. Cut damage **never heals by itself**; it must be bandaged with a **First Aid Kit**, and even then the last sliver of cut damage on a limb will not recover without another bandaging. This is why you always carry a medkit: a character who survives a fight at 1 health can still die of an unbandaged cut while limping home.
- **Blunt (stun) damage** — the aches. Stun damage is the blunt shock to a body part, it regenerates on its own, and no bandage is needed. It is what makes heavy hits knock people out while the underlying cuts still bleed.

The **Field Medic** skill governs all of this: how fast you bandage and how many kit charges each bandaging uses. A better-skilled medic bandages faster and stretches a kit further, which is why a dedicated healer in the squad pays for themselves. First Aid Kits are everywhere — NPCs carry them, shops stock them, and bandit corpses drop them — so scavenging is a reliable way to keep the squad's medical chest full.

Warning: A character uses the kit in their inventory before one in a backpack, and the lowest-quality kit first. When you loot a medkit off a corpse, put it in the healer's inventory — a medic who has to dig through a backpack mid-fight is a medic who is about to get interrupted.

Making Your First Cats

The currency of Kenshi is **cats**, and your first objective as a wanderer is to get some. The fastest and safest way in The Hub is mining copper.

Tip: There are copper and iron nodes within walking distance of The Hub's gates — the Kenshi wiki confirms "several copper and iron nodes within walking distance from the gates make it possible to run a fairly safe mining operation inside of the Hub." You do not need to travel to find ore. Follow the green-glowing outcrops of rock just outside the walls.

To mine, select your character, hold **right-click** on a copper outcrop and choose **Mine**. Your character will chip away, using the **Labouring** skill and filling their inventory with copper ore. Each unit of copper weighs 4 kg and sells for roughly **180 cats** at a shop, and since carrying it trains your Strength at the same time, a mining session is effectively paid training.

When your inventory is full, walk back into The Hub and sell: hold **right-click** on a shopkeeper — the bar's barman buys copper — and choose **Trade**. Drag your copper over to the sell column and take the cats. A single good haul of copper is several hundred cats; a couple of full runs gets you your first thousand.

Tip: Hold **Shift + right-click** on a copper node to set mining it as a repeating job. Your character will mine, and if you later buy a small shack and build ore storage, you can automate hauling — but for the first day, a backpack and a walk to the trader is all you need.

Warning: Bandits roam the Border Zone, and dust bandits know exactly where the Hub's miners work. Stay within sight of the walls, mine during the day, and the moment you see a red ring on a hostile, drop the pick and run for the gates — town guards and bar patrons do the fighting for you.

Jobs: Making Your Characters Work for You

Kenshi's real time-saver is **jobs**: ordered lists of commands you set once and your characters carry out on their own. You give a job by holding **Shift + right-click** on something and choosing a task — mine copper, haul ore, medic, and so on — and the job appears in the character's **Jobs** window. With Jobs enabled, the character works down the list from top to bottom: if the first job can't be done right now (no copper in reach, nothing to haul), they move to the next one, and when the first becomes possible again they come back to it.

Job types worth knowing from day one:

- **Work** — anything at a machine or farm; at Wave 0 this is mining, and later it is every workshop in your outpost.
- **Auto-haul** — carry produced items to a storage building. This is how a mining operation sustains itself: one character mines, another carries the copper to an ore storage box, and the pile builds while you are elsewhere.
- **First Aid / Medic** — treat wounded squadmates. Medic jobs stay active even when Jobs is toggled off, so a medic always patches up the squad after a fight.
- **Collection** — find dead bodies and take them to a corpse furnace, or loot the bodies of fallen animals.

Tip: Jobs are how one wanderer becomes a one-person town. Set mining, auto-haul to storage, and medic as jobs, and your character keeps the operation running while you walk to the trader to sell. The Hub's ruined shack can hold an ore box — start your empire in a building you did not pay for.

Trading and Shopping in The Hub

Kenshi is a trader's game as much as a fighter's, and knowing the shops is half the trick. The Hub is a small ruined town, and its shops are few but functional:

- **The Bar** — owned by the Trade Ninjas, this is the heart of The Hub. The barman buys your copper and ore, sells food, and the bar itself is where hirelings gather. It is your first and most important trading partner.
- **The Thieves Guild** — the town's second shop, worth knowing for the less legitimate side of trade.
- **Small Shacks** — the ruined residential buildings. Not shops, but many are **for sale**, and a collapsed shack costs a fraction of what the same space would run in a richer town.

Two pricing truths shape every trade you make:

- **Shops sell at a markup and buy at a discount.** Copper sells to you for its listed price, but a shop pays far less for what you sell than it charges for what you buy — the game applies a resale cut on looted and mined goods. Do not expect to sell a sword back at what it "cost".
- **Prices vary.** The wiki notes that food prices in particular "may actually differ in your game" because of price randomization. So a good deal in one shop may be a bad deal in another — and the same haul of copper is worth more in a town that needs it.

Tip: Buy food where it is cheap and sell ore where it is wanted. The bar's barman buys copper all day, and the traders' shops restock — a routine of "mine by the gates, sell at the bar, buy food before nightfall" is the whole early economy of The Hub.

Your First Recruit

You do not have to survive alone. Bars across Kenshi are full of people looking for work, and **The Hub's bar is one of the best places to start** — it frequently hosts hirelings.

To recruit, approach a character marked “looking for work”, **right-click** them and choose **Talk**, then pick the recruitment dialogue. If you have enough cats, they join your squad permanently — they are yours to command, equip, and train like any character you created.

The cost. Hiring is not free. A generic “sword for hire” recruit costs roughly **3,000 cats** at base, and more the better their skills are. Unique characters with names and backstories cost more still, and a few are free, but for your first companion a standard hireling is the dependable choice.

Tip: A second pair of hands changes the game. Put one character on the copper node while the other stands watch, or send one to scavenge bandit corpses while the other guards. The Hub’s bar is cheap to reach, the hirelings are weak but willing, and two weak wanderers beat one strong one every time.

Tip: On the Wanderer start, you may find **Hobbs** at The Hub’s bar, who might ask you to come have a drink with him — a friendly face before the wasteland shows you its own. Not every character worth talking to is a hireling; some are stories waiting to be heard.

Warning: New recruits start almost as weak as you did. Do not send a fresh hireling into a dust bandit camp expecting a hero — gear them from your spare loot, keep them fed from the shared backpack, and let them train alongside you where the fights are safe.

Camping and the Outdoors

Sooner or later you will sleep outside the walls — a scavenging trip runs long, a night catches you on the road, or the ruins you want to search have no inn. Kenshi gives you the tools for it:

- **Camping equipment** — tents and sleeping bags. A tent gives you a place to camp in the wilderness, and sleeping in a bed or camp bed multiplies healing over standing around. A campfire lets you cook food, which turns cheap raw ingredients into more nutritious meals.
- **Where you camp matters.** The Border Zone is lawless — a tent pitched in the open at night is an invitation to starving bandits and worse. Camp somewhere defensible, keep a watchful character up, and be ready to pack and run.
- **Food on the road.** A squad’s food is shared from any member’s backpack, so one person can carry bread for everyone. Before you leave The Hub, make sure the pack has more meals than the trip should take — the desert is merciless to the unprepared, and there is no convenience store halfway to Squin.

Tip: You do not have to fight the night. If a route is dangerous after dark, camp until morning instead — a night spent in a tent in a safe spot is cheaper than a funeral. Camping is a survival skill, not a luxury, and Wave 0 is the wave to practise it on short, safe trips.

The Survival Loop

From here on, Kenshi is a loop, and mastering it is the whole game. Each cycle makes you a little stronger, a little richer, and a little harder to kill:

1. **Eat.** Keep food in the squad’s backpack — bread, dried meat or cooked vegetables from the Hub’s traders. Hunger refills itself as long as food exists; the moment it does not, every other part of the loop starts failing.
2. **Heal.** After any fight, bandage the cuts, check for bleeding, and sleep. Beds heal eight times faster than standing around, so rent one at a bar or use the free beds in the ruined shack in The Hub when you can.

3. **Fight.** Pick fights you can win — starving bandits first, dust bandits once you have a companion. Fight near town where the walls and the bar are a step away.
4. **Level.** Every stat trains through use, and losing is not failing: getting knocked down and getting back up is how Toughness grows. Let the loop feed itself.
5. **Repeat.** The first week you scrape by on copper and scraps; by the end of the first month you will be the reason the dust bandits avoid the road.

Tip: The Hub has a small shack with two free beds you can use to heal — the wiki notes it “can help speed up the healing rate of your characters.” Enter with caution, though: not everyone inside is friendly.

Warning: Never leave the gates without food, bandages, and a plan. In Kenshi the difference between an adventure and an obituary is usually a backpack with one loaf of bread and one medical kit.

Your First Week: A Sample Routine

The mechanics above become muscle memory through repetition, so here is a concrete first week — the same shape your actual first week will take, with room to improvise:

Day 1 — the first copper. Mine by The Hub’s gates until your backpack is full, sell at the bar, and repeat until you have a few hundred cats. Buy a medkit and food before nightfall; sleep in The Hub’s ruined shack or rent a bed.

Day 2 — the first companion. With a few hundred cats saved, check The Hub’s bar for a hireling “looking for work”. A standard recruit costs roughly 3,000 cats at base, so you may need a third day of mining first — but as soon as one joins, split the labour: one mines, one stands watch.

Days 3–5 — the first honest fights. Now that you have a partner, let starving bandits come to you near the gates. Fight near town, bandage after, and let the losses be training: Toughness climbs every time you get back up. Keep selling copper to fund better gear and more food.

Days 5–7 — the first outpost job. By now you can set up a mining job loop (mine → auto-haul to storage → medic) so the operation runs while you trade. When the dust bandits start being a nuisance, you have a choice — keep grinding in The Hub, or set out for Squin to the west and see what the wider world asks of you.

Tip: Write nothing down; Kenshi remembers it for you. The game tracks every stat gain, every recruit, every injury. If your plan for the week collapses, the correct response is not reloading — it is limping home, healing up, and learning why the plan collapsed. That is the game.

Common Beginner Mistakes

- **Wandering at night.** Darkness hides enemies, and the desert is full of things that hunt in it. Camp, or keep to the streets of a town, after sunset. Your character will walk through the dark cheerfully — you have to choose not to.
- **Triggering aggro.** Getting too close to hostile squads, animals, or the wrong side of a faction fight. Learn the red rings, respect aggro ranges, and use right-click retreat the moment something hostile turns toward you.
- **Carrying no food.** Leaving with an empty backpack means fainting on the road, starving in a ditch, and losing everything. Food is not optional cargo; it is the one thing you never leave without.
- **Fighting fair fights.** Kenshi punishes honour. Use town guards, use the bar, use numbers, use the terrain — and use retreat. Winning an ugly fight is still winning.

- **Ignoring bleeding.** Surviving a fight at 1 health then bleeding out on the way home is the classic beginner death. Bandage cuts before you loot; corpses will wait.
 - **Overloading yourself.** Carrying far more than your strength allows slows you to a crawl and can get you caught by anything. Stay under half your carry weight when travelling, and accept that the copper will still be there tomorrow.
 - **Mining far from the gates.** The nodes in the distance are the same copper as the nodes by the wall, but the distant ones come with a dust bandit tax. Mine where the town can save you.
- None of these are fatal lessons. Kenshi expects you to make them, survive them, and come back stronger — that is the point of the loop. By the time the loop stops scaring you, you will be ready to leave The Hub behind, and that is where Wave 1: The Outlander begins.

The Wanderer: Modlist

Wave 0 adds no content. Every mod in this chapter only makes the game easier to see, smoother to run, or less tedious to operate — nothing here raises your stats, your damage, or your income beyond what vanilla Kenshi allows, and nothing adds new weapons, armour, or factions. Think of it as polishing the window before you step through it.

Install order: subscribe to all six, then in the KMM Mods tab drag **Compressed Textures Project** to the very top and **Kenshi CTD fix patch** to the very bottom; the rest can sit between them. The six mods are split across the next two sections by what they change. **Mechanics** covers the four engine/performance mods (Compressed Textures Project, Particle System Override, Kenshi Performance Fix, Kenshi CTD fix patch) — nothing that touches balance, just smoother and more stable running. **Graphics** covers the two readability mods (Dark UI and Nice Map) — how the game looks, not how it plays.

The Wanderer: Mechanics

These four mods do not add content — they change how the engine performs. Each one removes an inefficiency in Kenshi's OGRE-era engine (per-frame texture conversion, broken meshes, broken shaders, animation crashes) so the game runs smoother and more stable on 1.0.68. None of them touch stats, damage, prices or caps, so the power-spike test is passed untouched.

Compressed Textures Project

Version/Updated: Posted 9 Feb 2019 (no updates since)

Verified: YES — Steam Workshop page fetched; title matches

Dependencies: None — self-contained

Impact: Re-compresses every landscape texture from 2048 to 1024 and other assets from 4096 to 2048 in DXT5, cutting loading times, stuttering and VRAM use with almost no visible quality loss.

Notes: 16,290 ratings, 753k+ subscribers. 1.339 GB download. Author instruction: place above all other mods. No save import required. If you later adopt RE_Kenshi, its built-in compression supersedes this mod.

Particle System Override (PSO)

Version/Updated: Updated 21 Jul 2024

Verified: YES — Nexus page fetched; title matches

Dependencies: None — self-contained (installer; Steam and GOG)

Impact: Kenshi ships particle images as .PNG files that the engine converts to .DDS every time they load, causing hitches. PSO pre-converts every particle to DXT-compressed .DDS, removing the per-frame conversion cost and stabilising FPS during fights, weather and in foliage-heavy zones.

Notes: Tagged Performance Optimization on Nexus. An installer walks you through the swap and keeps backups. Designed to pair with Kenshi Performance Fix (run PSO first).

Kenshi Performance Fix

Version/Updated: Updated 8 Jul 2023

Verified: YES — Nexus page fetched; title matches

Dependencies: None — but pairs with Particle System Override (run PSO first)

Impact: One-pass overhaul that fixes broken engine meshes, repairs broken shader files, and applies the same particle and water optimisations as PSO, reducing crashes and improving frame pacing across the whole game.

Notes: Installer-based (Steam and GOG). Version 1.3 reworked its missing-file set to align with PSO. Alongside the CTD patch this is the standard stability core of most Kenshi modlists.

Kenshi CTD fix patch

Version/Updated: Updated 30 May 2024

Verified: YES — Nexus page fetched; title matches

Dependencies: None — self-contained

Impact: Fixes animation-related crashes-to-desktop and adds alerts for broken save files; on first launch it auto-generates a small patch mod that repairs invalid race-animation references before they can crash the game.

Notes: Updated a month after the 1.0.68 release, so it is current with the target build. The generated patch must sit at the very end of the load order. Widely recommended in community modlists (UWE/KAIZO etc.).

The Wanderer: Graphics

The two mods in this section change how the game **looks** — the interface skin and the world map — without changing how the game plays. Wave O keeps the world's own textures and colours untouched; these two purely improve readability and comfort.

Dark UI

Version/Updated: Updated 9 Aug 2020 (posted 13 Nov 2017)

Verified: YES — Steam Workshop page fetched; title matches

Dependencies: None — self-contained

Impact: Recolours the entire interface to a dark, high-contrast theme that is much easier to read through dust storms and long nights, and is the community-standard base skin that other UI mods build on.

Notes: 11,897 Steam ratings, the most-subscribed Kenshi UI mod. Best at 1920x1080 borderless; Kenshi's UI scales poorly on some resolutions. Nexus mirror: [Dark UI](#).

Nice Map [Zones + Zone names + Roads]

Version/Updated: Updated 29 Jan 2019 (posted 3 Jan 2019)

Verified: YES — Steam Workshop page fetched; title matches

Dependencies: None — self-contained

Impact: Replaces the world-map texture with a hand-crafted version that shows zone outlines, zone names and roads, making travel planning dramatically clearer for a new wanderer.

Notes: 8,103 ratings, 626k+ subscribers. Pure GUI_Map.dds texture swap; author confirmed in Nov 2025 that Kenshi's map texture is unchanged and the mod still works. The road-only 'Nice Map' style also exists for purists.

Wave 1: The Outlander

The Outlander: Strategy

Wave 0 ended with you leaving The Hub — a few hundred cats richer, a recruit or two by your side, and the survival loop running on muscle memory. Wave 1 is the next rung up the ladder: leaving the town's walls behind and building a home of your own. This chapter is the strategy for that leap — how to read the land, lay out an outpost that can grow, feed people, dig up stone and iron, and survive the first time somebody decides your outpost should not exist. The mods in this wave make survival and settlement richer, not easier; every card in the mod sections exists to deepen the problem, not to solve it for you.

The single most important thing to internalise is that an outpost is a **declaration**. The moment your buildings form a town, the world notices. You stop being a wanderer to be robbed and become a settlement to be taxed, prayed at, and raided. Everything in this chapter flows from that fact: you build walls because raids exist, you farm because food has to come from somewhere, and you choose your land carefully because what the land gives you decides how hard the first year will be.

Warning: Do not build your first outpost until your squad can beat a starving-bandit pack cleanly, you have a few thousand cats in reserve, and at least one character can carry their own weight in Building Materials without crawling. An outpost is a **commitment** — the moment it exists, the game starts sending you bills.

Reading the Landscape

A base site is a bundle of resources, and Kenshi's **Prospecting** action is how you read them. Have a character with some **Science** use Prospecting on the spot you are considering, and the results screen gives you the environment and four resource values you actually care about:

- **Environment** — which soil type the zone is on (Arid, Green, or Swamp). The environment is fixed per zone, and it sets a hard ceiling on what you can farm there.
- **Water** — how efficiently **wells** will draw. The wiki notes that, broadly, lower elevation means higher water, which is why valley floors and riverbanks prospect better than ridgelines.
- **Fertility** — how efficiently **farms** will grow crops. This is the number that decides whether your first wheatstraw field is a larder or a graveyard.
- **Stone** — how efficiently **stone mines** will produce building stone.
- **Iron** — how efficiently you can mine **raw iron**, and it also shows you where the iron outcrops sit on the prospecting map. Copper appears on the same map when you toggle it.

Read the whole map, not just your own spot. The site you build on matters, but the site you build **near** matters just as much: a base a day's walk from a trading town is a different beast from one planted in the deep wilderness. Fertile land near a town means you can sell surplus crops; deep land with high ore means you will haul every loaf in yourself.

Tip: Prospect at least three candidate sites before you commit a single Building Material. Kenshi has no “undo” for a bad base — you can move, but dismantling and rebuilding an outpost costs days. Ten minutes of scouting is cheaper than a week of rebuilding.

The wiki's own community guide names the classic early spots, and each one teaches a different lesson:

- **Shem** — “the promised land” to the veterans: big deposits (100 iron, 80 copper on many sites), wide flat ground for a town that will grow, and fields of high-richness stone. It is also home to roaming Garru and Beak Things — free meat and skins, and a danger to a weak squad.

- **Okran's Pride** — fertile, safe, and well-guarded by roving Holy Nation paladins, which makes it the classic “safe” early base. The catch is the prayer day: the Holy Nation will visit your outpost and expects everyone home, and passing sentinels take issue with any non-humans working there.
- **The Border Zone / Howler Maze belt** — near the familiar ground of The Hub, with decent copper and iron, and the same lawlessness you already know how to survive.

Warning: Never build in a faction's territory without understanding the faction. The Holy Nation visits with Prayer Day, the United Cities with tax men, the Shek Kingdom with tribute rounds, and the Hounds with plain extortion — the wiki documents all four as outpost visits. Pick the landlord you can live with before you pick the view.

Proximity is part of the deal too. The wiki's raid page ties raids to distance: a base planted near the camps of hostile factions invites their attention, and the closer you sit, the more often they come calling. That is not an argument for building far from everything — it is an argument for knowing who your neighbours are **before** you build. A base near Starving Bandit camps gets starving-bandit raids; a base near nothing gets nothing, and also no trade, no bounties and no safety net. Choose the radius, do not stumble into it.

First Outpost Layout

Start smaller than you want to, and make room for what comes next. The first outpost is not your forever city; it is a farm and a workshop that earns the money and food to build the real thing. The build menu is organised into categories — Buildings, Camping, Crafting, Defence, Farming, Food, Interior, Lights, Mining, Power, Storage, Tech, Training, and Walls — and you will touch almost all of them in the first month, so leave clear lanes between buildings for the walls you will add later.

A footprint that scales, in order of construction:

1. **A well, on high water.** Water first, because everything — farms, cooking, your own thirst — runs on it. The wiki is blunt: “a vital source of water, you won't last long without it.” Prospecting found the spot; build the well there, not where the flat ground is.
2. **One or two farms, on high fertility, matching your environment.** At first the only crop that matters is the one that grows well where you are. A farm needs a worker and a water supply — set a **Work** job for the field and an **Auto-haul** job to carry water from the well to the farm's storage.
3. **A stone mine and an ore store.** Stone becomes Building Materials, which becomes every wall you will ever place. Iron and copper become your income. Put their storage boxes close to the mines — hauling time is the real cost of an outpost.
4. **Sleeping quarters and a fire.** A building shell to shelter your people and a campfire or stove to turn raw food into meals. Beds multiply healing, which matters the moment the first raid happens.
5. **Leave a ring of empty ground.** The single most expensive mistake in base building is filling your footprint before you need it. Walls want space, and a wall that has to be squeezed around already-built structures is a wall with holes in it.

Tip: Farms can be upgraded in place — a Small farm becomes Medium becomes Large, and crops still in the field count toward the upgrade. Build your farms small and cheap on day one, then upgrade them as your farming skill and water supply grow. The wiki confirms upgrades carry over the crops still planted.

Warning: An outpost with no walls and no gate is a buffet. The wiki's own outpost guide warns that until you build walls and a gate, wild animals and bandits will “constantly harass you.” Build

the well, the farms and the mines on day one, but schedule the walls before the end of the first month — not after the first night they were needed.

Walls, Gates & Defense-in-Depth

Walls are the difference between an outpost and an invitation. The research chain is short and mandatory: **Makeshift Walls** first, then **Defensive Walls**, which the in-game description sums up as “solid walls that we can actually stand and build turrets on.” Defensive walls let you mount turrets, and from that moment your wall stops being a delay and becomes a weapon platform.

Defense-in-depth for a growing outpost, in layers:

1. **The wall itself.** A continuous ring with no gaps, built on the flat lanes you reserved. Gap-free matters more than thick: raiders path through the first opening they find.
2. **The gate.** The gate is the weakest point on purpose — raiders break gates down, so the gate gets the most turrets and the most guards. The wiki's raid description has raiders literally “breaking down gates” to get in, which is why every gate in your wall should be covered by fire.
3. **Turrets on the wall line.** After Defensive Walls, put turrets on the wall segments beside the gate and on corners. A turret on a wall sees raiders approach while they are still out of melee range.
4. **A kill lane.** Keep the ground just inside the gate clear of buildings, so anyone who breaks through lands in open ground where your gunners and heavies can meet them — not in your farm.
5. **Water as a moat.** The wiki's community guide notes that water can act as an excellent defensive measure if you build around it, “forcing hostiles to swim and slowing them down.” A base tucked against a pond or river needs fewer wall segments for the same defense.

Tip: Build the gate first, not last. A gate alone with walls still under construction gives you a chokepoint to defend while the rest of the ring catches up — and a chokepoint beats an open field every time.

Warning: Walls do not stop everything. The wiki's guide warns that some animals — Beak Things are the famous example — “can get stuck on and sometimes phase through any defensive walls you build.” A wall slows most raiders and stops most bandits, but it is not a force field. Keep your gate shut, keep someone awake, and keep your best fighters near the wall line, not in the kitchen.

Food Production: Farming vs Hunting vs Trade

Every mouth in your outpost eats, and food comes from three places — farming, hunting, and trade. The right mix depends on your land, and reading the land correctly is what makes the difference between a food surplus and a famine.

Farming is the backbone, and it is the most land-dependent. Kenshi has six farmable crops — Cactus, Cotton, Greenfruit, Hemp, Riceweed, and Wheatstraw — and each grows only in certain environments. The wiki's environment table is worth memorising in its essentials:

Crop	Arid	Green	Swamp	— — — —	Cactus	100%	0%	0%	Cotton	0%	100%	0%
	Greenfruit	0%	100%	0%	Hemp	40%	100%	100%	Riceweed	0%	0%	100%
	Wheatstraw	50%	100%	0%								

Every farm also needs a worker and a **water** supply, and growth rate depends on the site's fertility on top of the environment. The practical read: on arid land (most of the Border Zone), Cactus and Wheatstraw are your food crops; in Green zones you can grow anything except cactus and riceweed; in the Swamp, Riceweed and Hemp are king. Cotton feeds nothing directly but becomes fabric, and Hemp becomes textiles and hashish — both are cash crops as much as food crops.

There is an escape hatch, and it is a late-game one: **hydroponics**. The wiki's hydroponics pages are specific about the cost — Research Bench V and an AI Core to unlock the tree, then Ancient Science Books for each crop you want to grow indoors. Hydroponic farms ignore environment and fertility entirely, which is the long-term answer to the resource table above: a swamp lord or desert hermit who gets tired of growing only what the land allows can, eventually, grow anything anywhere. That is not a Wave 1 priority — the AI Cores alone put it out of reach for a first-year outpost — but knowing it exists changes how you read your land. The environment is not a cage; it is a timetable.

Hunting is the protein your farms cannot provide quickly. Garru, wild bulls, bonedogs and (carefully) Beak Things drop meat and skins; the wiki's outpost guide highlights roaming animals as “free meat and skins” in several recommended start areas. Hunting trains combat stats while it feeds you, but it is dangerous and unpredictable — a food plan that relies on hunting is a food plan that can have a very bad week.

Trade is the backstop. Food can always be bought in towns, and the wiki notes that price randomization means deals vary between shops. An outpost near a town can sell its surplus crops and buy what its land cannot grow; a deep-wilderness outpost must be self-sufficient or die proud. The classic pattern is: farm a staple, hunt the meat, and trade only the difference.

Tip: Farming skill matters more than field size. The wiki's farming page warns that untrained farmers “waste many crops and will likely lead to a food shortage.” Train your farmers cheaply first: work the town farms of a nearby settlement for free — the wiki confirms nobody minds, the crops you take have no stolen tag, and with no outpost you face no raids. When your farmer is skilled, **then** plant your own fields.

Warning: Do not plant a field that outruns your water. Farms consume water every growth cycle, and a well on low-water ground will not keep up. Build the well on the prospected water first, upgrade it to Well II and III as the fields grow, and only plant as much as the well can actually water.

Stone & Iron Logistics

Your outpost runs on stone and iron as much as on food. Stone becomes Building Materials — every wall, gate, turret and building shell consumes them — and iron and copper become both your income and your future weapons. The logistics of moving raw ore around are the hidden workload of base building, and jobs are how you automate it.

The wiki's prospecting page separates the two resources cleanly: **stone** measures how efficiently **stone mines** produce, and **iron** measures how efficiently you mine raw iron, with the map showing you where the outcrops sit. Both are mined with the **Labouring** skill you already trained on copper in The Hub — an outpost turns that first-wave skill into a full-time job.

The flow to automate, in job terms:

- **Mining** — a **Work** job on the stone mine and the ore outcrops. One worker per node, on repeat.
- **Hauling** — an **Auto-haul** job carrying the raw ore and stone from the machine to the storage box next to it. The wiki's jobs list describes auto-haul exactly: characters carry items to the related storage building from their inventory, the ground, or the machine itself.
- **Processing** — a second **Work** job turning stone into Building Materials and raw iron into iron plates at the appropriate workbench. This is the step that turns rocks into walls.

Tip: One miner, one hauler, one processor is a complete economic cell. Three jobs, three characters, and a pile of stone that grows while you are off trading. Add storage boxes as the bottleneck moves — the bottleneck in every outpost is almost always hauling distance, not production.

Warning: Storage boxes that sit too far from the mine double your hauling time and your hauler's hunger. Put the ore store beside the mine and the finished-goods store beside the workbench, and let the hauler run a short loop, not a marathon.

The Outpost Job Board

An outpost only works when the work runs without you. The wiki's jobs page is precise about the system: jobs are an ordered command list — set them up with Shift+right-click — and a character works top-to-bottom, skipping to the next job when the current one can't be done, and returning to it when it can. That behaviour is the whole engine of a self-running outpost, and it rewards you for designing job lists the way you design walls: with fallbacks.

The job types matter as much as the order. **Work** jobs keep a station manned (mining, farming, crafting). **Auto-haul** jobs carry items from the machine, the ground, or the character's own inventory to the related storage building — the wiki describes it exactly that way, which is why a well placed next to a farm with an auto-haul to the field's storage waters it without a single click. **First Aid / Medic** and **Collection** round out the list, and a medic job on your weakest character is worth more than a third wall segment.

A healthy outpost job board, in order:

1. **Auto-haul (well to farm storage)** — water, non-negotiable, runs all day.
2. **Work (field)** — the farmer tends the crops.
3. **Work (kitchen)** — cook what the field brings in.
4. **Work (mines)** then **Work (workbench)** — ore to plates, stone to Building Materials.
5. **First Aid / Medic** — on every character; the job list skips it until someone is hurt, and then it is the difference between a wound and a funeral.

Tip: Give every fighter a medic job as their **last** priority. The list skips down to it only when no one needs rescuing, so the job costs you nothing in peacetime and saves the squad in the one minute it matters. Wave O taught you to bandage; the job board just makes it automatic.

Managing the First Raid

The first raid is not a failure state — it is the moment the outpost stops being a construction project and becomes a settlement. Kenshi's raids are **territorial events**: the wiki's raid page documents that raids trigger when your base sits near the camps of hostile factions, with the chance scaling with proximity. A base in the Border Zone earns its place in the world; the Starving Bandits, Dust Bandits, or Black Dragon Ninjas will come to collect.

Raid behaviour is predictable once you know what to expect. Raiders assault your base in squads, and the raid description has them give a speech before “ordering the attack to begin, breaking down gates, attacking characters.” They path to the gate, they break it down, and they flood through the kill lane. That predictability is the whole point of defense-in-depth: the raid arrives at the gate, and the gate is where you have the turrets, the gunners, and the heavies.

Scale scales. The wiki's raid page documents a mid-game example — the Band of Bones, who assault bases with two to four squads of four to seven raiders each — and the numbers matter for planning: a squad of that size is a fight, not a skirmish, and it arrives as **waves** rather than a single push. Small raids are single squads; the number of squads and the numbers in them both grow with your settlement's footprint. Your first raid is usually manageable; your tenth raid, on a richer outpost, is a small army that expects to win.

On top of the armed raids come the **visits**: tax men from the United Cities, prayer days from the Holy Nation, tribute rounds from the Shek Kingdom, and extortion from the Hounds. The wiki's outpost

guide is specific about the options: you can respond to these squads in a way that avoids conflict, or you can refuse — in which case “they might be immediately attacked, or the squad will retreat with the promise of returning with an army.” Paying the tax is cheaper than fighting the army, when the tax is affordable.

Tip: Let the first raid come to the gate. Do not chase raiders across the countryside — every bandit you fight at the wall is one your turrets softened first. Fall back inside, hold the kill lane, and let the raid break itself against the gate while your gunners work.

Warning: Raid size tracks your settlement’s reputation. A tiny two-building shack earns small, disorganised raids; a rich, sprawling city attracts proper armies. Grow your walls and your squad at the same speed, or the first time the world notices how big you have become will also be the last time you underestimate a raid.

Tip: After the fight, the wounded heal eight times faster in beds than standing around, and unbandaged cuts bleed out while you celebrate. Bandage first, drag the heavy casualties to beds, and only then loot the corpses and check what the raiders dropped. Wave 0’s rules still apply — the difference is now you have a home to defend.

The Outlander’s First Year

The arc of Wave 1 is the arc of building something permanent in a world that does not want it. It will not go to plan, and that is the plan.

Month one — the foothold. Prospect, choose your land, and build the five-item footprint: well, farms, stone mine, ore storage, and a place to sleep. No walls yet — you are too small to attract armies, and the animals you can handle. Your goal is a single full food cycle: plant, water, harvest, cook, eat. Until that loop closes, you have an expensive camp; once it closes, you have an outpost.

Months two and three — the ring. Research Makeshift Walls, then Defensive Walls, and build the ring around the footprint. Your first genuine raid likely arrives in this window — probably from whoever owns the nearest camps. Let it come to the gate. You will lose people, or nearly; bandage, bury, and learn why the raid found you, because the answer is usually “your base is big enough to matter now.”

Months four through six — the economy. With the ring up, expand production: more farms, a proper workshop, a surplus of stone and food. Trade the surplus to nearby towns, buy the seeds and blueprints your land cannot produce, and hire. A settlement that only feeds itself is a farm; a settlement with a surplus is a town.

Months seven through twelve — the choice. By the end of the first year the outpost runs without you micromanaging it — jobs drive the mines, the fields and the storages, and the raids are routine. Now the world starts offering the deeper questions: the faction that keeps taxing you, the ruins just over the ridge, the forge that wants a smith. That is where Wave 1 hands off to the next chapter: a survivor who built a home, about to decide what to make of it.

Tip: Nothing in Kenshi forgives you for not writing things down — the game remembers for you, in the bodies you bury and the walls you build. The outpost that survives its first year is the one whose owner treated every raid as tuition: each one told you where the wall was thin, which fighter was weak, and how much food you needed to hold out. Listen, and the second year is easy.

Warning: Do not over-expand into debt. Every new building, recruit and farm is a mouth and a target. Kenshi's economy punishes the glorious over-reach exactly once, and that once is how many settlements the world needs. Grow the footprint, hold the ring, feed the mouths you have — the first year is about surviving your own ambition.

The Outlander: Modlist

Wave 1 adds the settlement layer: buildings, food production, water, weather and the light survival mechanics that turn a camp into a home. Nothing here raises combat power — no new weapons, armour, stats or caps. Every mod either deepens a survival problem (water, food, farming on hostile land) or gives you more to build with (buildings, furniture, atmosphere). Think of it as the toolset for the strategy chapter that opened this wave.

Install order: subscribe to all ten, then in the KMM Mods tab make sure **Slopeless** sits **above Forgotten Buildings** (the author requires it — wrong order makes some buildings impossible to place), and keep **Compressed Textures Project** from Wave 0 above all Wave 1 content so the building textures render correctly. **Mood Weather** recommends pairing with Wave 0's **Particle System Override**. Do **not** run **Fish and Meat Industry** together with the older **Meat Production and Processing** — the author says it supersedes that mod.

The ten mods are split across the next three sections by what they change. **Mechanics** covers the survival-system changes (Radiant Food Expansion, Deep Wells, Moisture Farming) — how food and water actually work. **Content** covers the new buildables and additions (Vanilla Outposts Expanded, Fish and Meat Industry, Shek Perfect Body) — what you can build and craft. **Graphics** covers the visual layer (Mood Weather, Flipped Buildings, Forgotten Buildings, Slopeless) — how the world and your outpost look.

The Outlander: Mechanics

These three mods change how the survival loop works — how food is produced, how water is found, and how crops grow on hostile land. None of them hand you food or water for free; they expand the **paths** to it, and each path comes with a cost in research, skill or setup. That keeps them on the right side of the power-spike test: they raise the ceiling of what an outpost can sustain, but only at the price of the investment the strategy chapter describes.

Radiant Food Expansion

Version/Updated: Updated 14 Jan 2025 (posted 16 Jun 2022)

Verified: YES — Steam Workshop page fetched twice (2026-08-03); title matches

Dependencies: None — self-contained; author notes most assets are independent and should not create compatibility issues

Impact: Expands the food economy: new cooking research, a new main food crop for the Swamp biome (sold by vendors and cultivatable), new realistic food dishes with custom lore-friendly icons at different nutrition grades, restoration of Gristle-Flaps, more uses for fish, balanced nutrition values and prices, special food for animals, a new contraband item (Devil Wine), and full fishing implementation.

Notes: 577 Steam ratings. The author's own description banner reads 'Last updated on 13/02/2023' but the Workshop changelog shows later activity to 14 Jan 2025. Focused on the Swamp start that vanilla under-serves; pairs naturally with Wave 1's farming strategy.

Deep Wells

Version/Updated: Posted 3 Feb 2018 (no updates since)

Verified: YES — Steam Workshop page fetched (2026-08-03); title matches; author comment in same thread confirms it still works on current Kenshi

Dependencies: Requires Wells III research

Impact: Adds a deep well that draws water from underground rivers and does not require surface water in the area — opening base sites on dry land that vanilla would starve for water.

Notes: ~62,000 subscribers, 223 ratings. In the first comment the author wrote 'I was 90% positive mod broke somewhere along the updates... Thank you for checking this out' after a user confirmed it still works — the strongest community signal a 2018 water mod remains functional on 1.0.68.

Moisture Farming

Version/Updated: Posted 5 Mar 2018 (1 change note, 2018)

Verified: YES — Steam Workshop page fetched (2026-08-03); title matches

Dependencies: Tech level 3 + Wells 3 + 1 Ancient Science Book

Impact: Adds the Moisture Collector, which gathers water passively from the air and is buildable indoors and outdoors — letting desert outposts and in-town hydroponics labs water themselves without wells or micromanaged hauling.

Notes: 3,122 ratings, 289 comments. Requires the stated research or it will not appear in the build menu. Author documents a known navmesh quirk where Collectors can stop hauling to storage (a vanilla Kenshi bug) and gives the Ctrl+Shift+F11 NavMesh rebuild as the fix.

The Outlander: Content

These three mods add what you can build and craft — more buildings for your outpost, more ways to turn raw land into food, and more of Kenshi's look on your own characters. The rule for this wave is that content has to aid survival and settlement, not combat: nothing here makes you hit harder. Vanilla Outposts Expanded is deliberately decorative in the vanilla style, Fish and Meat Industry is a food-production chain with real research costs, and Shek Perfect Body is a cosmetic body texture replacer (never-nude) that keeps the same model, just with a crisper finish.

Vanilla Outposts Expanded

Version/Updated: Updated 14 May 2022 (posted 10 Sep 2021)

Verified: YES — Steam Workshop page fetched twice (2026-08-03); title matches

Dependencies: None — self-contained (most blueprints bought from any construction vendor)

Impact: Gives you access to Kenshi assets that already exist in the world but not in the vanilla build menu: extra tables, barrels, carpets, signs, decorative chaos (smashed buildings and furniture), Holy Nation ambiance, Lagoon building variants, market stalls and tents, more lighting, old cube storage, quarry construction (scaffolds, cranes, stones) and Swamp structures — all vanilla assets, kept lore-friendly.

Notes: The author pitched it as the outpost that does not look like it exists 'just to make food and upgrade gear'. 393 ratings. Stays close to vanilla by construction — most changes are decorative, with a few items given a practical use.

Fish and Meat Industry

Version/Updated: Updated 25 Apr 2025 (posted 19 Apr 2025)

Verified: YES — Steam Workshop page fetched twice (2026-08-03); title matches

Dependencies: None — standalone; author warns DO NOT run together with the older 'Meat Production and Processing' (id 2985207405), which this supersedes

Impact: Adds alternative food-production lines for establishing bases in barren locations: Fishing (T1) and Advanced Fishing (T1) add fishing rod sets, nets, drying racks and fish recipes; Survival Cooking (T2) adds dried Gristle-Flaps, a campfire variant and a food store; Insect Farming (T2) adds a second food chain. New crafting recipes give vanilla's unused Medical Supplies a purpose.

Notes: By Ironmonk (author of Meat Production and Processing). The author is transparent that balancing is still settling — 'expect some balancing changes in the future'. New buildings mostly land in the Camping category and do not count as outpost buildings.

Shek Perfect Body (never nude)

Version/Updated: v1.0 (single release)

Verified: YES — Nexus page fetched (2026-08-03); title matches

Dependencies: None — standalone texture replacer

Impact: Replaces the vanilla Shek body texture with a higher-fidelity version that keeps all clothing and underwear fully intact — the 'never nude' variant, safe for work, with no body-model change and no stat effect. Purely cosmetic.

Notes: 196 endorsements. The only adult-category-adjacent mod in this guide, and it is the safe variant by design. Checked against the explicit-porn exclusion: this is a texture upgrade, not adult content.

The Outlander: Graphics

The four mods in this section change how the world and your outpost **look** — the weather overhead, the shape of the buildings you place, the flavour of old-world construction, and the ground under everything. None of them touches gameplay numbers, so the power-spike test is passed untouched. This is the wave where your base starts to look like **yours** instead of a copy of every other camp in the Border Zone.

Mood Weather

Version/Updated: Updated 12 Jan 2025 (posted 31 Jul 2024)

Verified: YES — Steam Workshop page fetched twice (2026-08-03); title matches

Dependencies: None — self-contained; author recommends pairing with Particle System Override and Reduced Particle Effects

Impact: Edits the vanilla weather system to be more beautiful and varied: recoloured clouds and fog, varying amounts of cloud in most weathers, wind and clouds in the Arm of Okran, ground-sand effects in dust storms, black rain in the Deadlands, and fog added to misty rain. Adds no new weather types and does not change how often weather occurs.

Notes: 75,814 subscribers, 630 ratings, by crunk aint dead. The compatibility note is important: it makes existing weather *look* better without touching frequency or new weather events, so it slots into the strategy chapter's 'read the landscape' advice unchanged.

Flipped Buildings

Version/Updated: Updated 15 Mar 2025 (posted 4 Dec 2021)

Verified: YES — Steam Workshop page fetched twice (2026-08-03); title matches

Dependencies: None — unlocks via the same techs as their vanilla counterparts (Small House, Medium Building shell, Large Building shell)

Impact: Adds 14 mirrored versions of vanilla buildings — Small Shack, Storm House (and Lagoon variant), Bughouse, Y-house, L-House (and Lagoon), Longhouse, Snailhouse (and Lagoon), Stephouse, Stationhouse, Watchtower, Broken Watchtower — which appear in a 'BUILDINGS - Flipped' category after researching the same techs as the originals.

Notes: 43,910 subscribers, by MARH. The author calls them 'simple mirror images of vanilla buildings' — pure layout variety for denser town planning, no stat or gameplay change. No save import required; dismantle flipped buildings before removing the mod.

Forgotten Buildings

Version/Updated: Updated Feb 2024 (posted 9 Jun 2019)

Verified: YES — Steam Workshop page fetched twice (2026-08-03); title matches

Dependencies: None — but load-order requirements (see Notes)

Impact: The largest collection of buildings and furniture from older Kenshi builds and non-player towns: over 400 new buildings and furniture pieces to construct plus another 300 copies with alternative textures. Includes Tier 5 and concrete walls, moor buildings, swamp buildings, platforms, walkways and fences, hive huts, cannibal shacks, metal buildings, outpost s-I/II/V, Lagoon buildings, outpost citadels and vast factory pieces.

Notes: ~28k subscribers, by Mechanica. Load-order rules from the page: Slopeless must sit *above* Forgotten Buildings (wrong order makes some buildings impossible to place), and texture mods like Compressed Textures Project must also load *above* it or some buildings appear too bright. Gives an old-world, ruined-town look that fits the Scars theme.

Slopeless

Version/Updated: Updated 26 Feb 2024 (posted 13 May 2019)

Verified: YES — Steam Workshop page fetched (2026-08-03); title matches

Dependencies: None — self-contained

Impact: Makes the ground flatten under buildings and walls as you place them, so you can build level floors and straight wall lines on terrain that vanilla would reject or slope. Removes one of the biggest frustrations of base building on uneven ground.

Notes: 5,388 ratings, 22 change notes, by Gyropilot. Author confirmed the 2024 update was reverted after testing and the current Workshop build is the stable one. Required reading for the strategy chapter's 'first outpost layout' — reserve your flat lanes, then let Slopeless keep them flat.

Wave 2: The Smith

The Smith: Strategy

Wave 1 ended with a walled outpost, a food surplus, and the first raid that did not break you. Wave 2 is the next rung: turning that outpost's raw iron, leather and labour into the machines, weapons and defences that decide how far you go. This is the chapter for the forge — the research tree, the crafting benches, the material economy that feeds them, and the smith who works them. The mods in this wave make production deeper, not easier; every card in the mod sections exists to gate a reward behind investment, never to hand it to you.

The single most important thing to internalise is that in Kenshi, **crafting is a ladder, not a menu**. Nothing worth forging starts unlocked. The research bench gates your tech level, the tech level gates your grades, the grades gate your materials, and your smith's skill gates the quality of everything that leaves the bench. A Wave 2 outpost that understands this order can arm itself against the world; one that does not will spend its months hammering Homemade junk while its enemies swing Catun steel.

Warning: Do not treat the forge as a side project. In the mid-game, your smith is your army's quartermaster: the quality of the weapons and armour your people carry is decided by the Smithing and Armour Smith skills of one or two characters, and those skills only rise by working the bench. Start your smith on day one of the wave, or the wave's raids will out-pace your gear.

The Research Tree, Mapped

The research tree is the skeleton of everything in this wave, and it runs on a single resource chain: research bench upgrades are paid for in iron plates, and each bench level **is** your tech level. The wiki's Research Bench page is specific about the ladder:

Bench	Iron Plates	Power	Efficiency	Research Bench II	10	0	90%	Research Bench III	20	10	95%	Research Bench IV	25	15	100%	Research Bench V	30	25	105%	Research Bench VI	35	30	110%
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The efficiency column is the bench's research-efficiency rating — higher is faster, so a Bench V at 105% out-paces a Bench II at 90% — and the power column matters the moment you leave the bench's zero-cost start: from Bench III onward a research bench is a power consumer, so your outpost's energy production has to grow in step with your research ambitions. Bench V is the gate every Wave 2 build eventually circles: it is the bench that unlocks **Hydroponics** (with an AI Core), and Expanded Craftable Weapons gates its Edge Type 1 research at Tech Level 5. If your outpost cannot produce or buy an AI Core, that is the wall your forge hits.

Tip: Budget research time like food. Every research item consumes bench time at the rate your bench's efficiency allows, and a faster bench compounds over a long tree — but the real cost is that a researcher on the bench is not mining, farming or guarding. Queue research overnight: put a character on the bench with a Work job before you log out or move the squad, and wake up to a finished node.

Which research actually matters for this wave, in order:

- **Weapon Smithing** — the tech line that unlocks craftable weapon models from Rusted Junk upward. The wiki's Weapon Smithing (Tech) page lists the ladder: Rusted Junk, Rusting Blade, Mid-Grade Salvage, Old Refitted Blade, Refitted Blade, Catun No.1 through No.3, Mk I through Mk III, then Edge Type 1, and Edge Type 2 — which vanilla only ever produces as a “critical success” from your smith, never directly.

- **Armour Smithing** — how armour grades are produced. Unlike weapons, the wiki's Armour Smith page confirms armour quality depends on the **Armour Smith skill** plus a small random factor, with no research required to unlock higher grades. More on this below.
- **Crossbow Crafting + Mounted Crossbows** — the tech line behind the crossbow economy and the turrets that use it. The Mounted Crossbows II research is the dependency for most of this wave's turret content.
- **Electrical Crafting** — unlocks the Electrical Workbench, which makes Electrical Components out of copper. The wiki describes components as “used in crafting and construction” — they are the mid-tier material your production chain consumes once the wave's machines start needing more than plates and bars.
- **Hydroponics** — the late-game food answer, unlocked at Bench V with an AI Core, with each crop costing Ancient Science Books.

RIY+ (The Scientific Method) plugs into the very top of this tree: it lets your researcher craft the **books** that research consumes. The catch is that the mod gates that ability behind research itself — you pay four books upfront to learn how to make books, and Ancient Science Books plus Engineering Research require higher tech levels before their recipes appear. It does not remove the book bottleneck; it moves it to a gate you can pay with bench time instead of caravan time.

Warning: The AI Core is the true end of this wave's research tree. Almost everything that matters late — hydroponics, Edge Type 1 weapons, top-tier robotics — asks for an AI Core, and the wiki's Hydroponics page is explicit that the tree's initial research “costs an AI Core.” They are the rare, hard-to-find component of the late game; if your outpost has no ruins runner and no luck looting, your forge tops out early. Plan the AI Core hunt before you plan the Edge Type forge.

The Weapon Forge

The weapon forge is where the material economy and the skill system meet. The wiki's Weapon Smithing (Tech) ladder is the map: your craftable model grade rises with the Weapon Smithing research tier, but the **quality** of each weapon you actually produce rises with your smith's Smithing skill and carries a random element on top.

The ladder, bottom to top:

- **Rusted Junk / Rusting Blade** — the junk tier. Cheap, weak, and mostly useful for training Smithing without wasting good materials.
- **Mid-Grade Salvage / Old Refitted Blade / Refitted Blade** — the workhorse band. Refitted blades are genuinely usable, and this is where most outposts live for the first half of the wave.
- **Catun No.1 / No.2 / No.3** — the serious tier. Catun steel is what bandit-town smiths dream of, and it starts needing steel bars and real bench time.
- **Mk I / Mk II / Mk III** — the high-grade tier. Mk III is the top of the vanilla **craftable** ladder; past this point vanilla locks the door.
- **Edge Type 1 / Edge Type 2** — Edge Type 1 is craftable at the top of the vanilla tree; Edge Type 2 only appears in vanilla as a critical success from a skilled smith, and the wiki is explicit that **there is no vanilla method to craft Edge Type 3 or Meitou yourself**.

That last sentence is the entire reason Expanded Craftable Weapons exists in this wave. It adds the research and recipes to forge Edge Type 3 and Meitou grade weapons — the two grades the base game keeps out of your hands — through a “Weapon Smith - All Grades” bench that unlocks with Weapon Smith III. The gating is appropriately brutal: Edge Type 1 demands Smithing 56, Tech Level 5 and an AI Core; Edge Type 2 demands Smithing 60. By the time your smith forges a Meitou, they have trained through the entire ladder and your outpost has fed an AI Core to the research bench.

Tip: Train your smith on the junk, not the good stuff. Rusted Junk and Rusting Blade recipes cost next to nothing, train Smithing just like the expensive ones, and the “failed” low-quality results are disposable. Save your steel bars and AI Cores for the moment your Smithing skill passes 50 — that is when the high-grade benches stop wasting good materials.

Diminishing returns are real, and they are the point. The stat difference between a Mk III and an Edge Type 1 is meaningful but not transformative; the difference between Edge Type 1 and Meitou is smaller still per step, while the cost — in AI Cores, rare materials, Smithing levels and bench time — climbs steeply. The power-spike test holds the line here: a Meitou is the best weapon in the game, but the path to it is the wave’s entire research-and-materials arc, not a shop purchase. If you are chasing Meitou, you are committing to the forge as a career.

The mod also balances the low end: Homemade weapons are boosted to match the existing craftable ones and crafted weapons sell for prices closer to looted equivalents. That closes a vanilla oddity where crafting your own gear felt like a tax — without ever letting crafting out-perform what the ladder’s top end costs.

Warning: A weapon’s grade is not its destiny — the smith’s skill is. Two Mk III blades from the same bench can differ meaningfully in quality because of the random element on top of the Smithing skill. Do not judge the forge by a single result; judge it by the average across a full batch.

Armour & the Protection Economy

Armour works on a different axis from weapons, and the difference matters. The wiki’s Armour Smith page confirms that armour quality depends on the Armour Smith skill plus a small random factor — and, unlike weapon grades, **no research is required to unlock higher armour grades**. A fresh Armour Smith at a Heavy Armour Smithy is already allowed to attempt the best armour in the game; the skill is what decides how often it comes out at that grade.

That makes armour production a **volume** game rather than a research game. Your Armour Smith’s skill rises by crafting, and the random factor means the same bench produces a spread of grades across a batch. The classic outpost strategy is to run the bench continuously, bank the good rolls, and grind the bad ones into scrap or sell them off at the armour shop’s 0.25x resale value — the wiki confirms armour sells for a quarter of its value.

The four benches, each for its own material band:

- **Leather Armour Crafting Bench** — the cheap start, fuelled by animal skins and the leather tanning line.
- **Clothing Bench** — fabric armour and clothing, fed by the cotton → fabric line.
- **Chain Armour Crafting Bench** — the mid-tier, and a serious consumer of steel bars (the wiki lists Chain Armour among steel bar uses).
- **Heavy Armour Smithy** — the top end, where plate armour and the heavy grades live, and the biggest consumer of iron plates, armour plating and bench time.

Armor Crafting Redux - Core reorganises this whole floor without touching a single number: recipes are alphabetised and grouped by bench and research node, blueprint clutter disappears, and unlocks come from research instead of hunting tiny shop icons. Its value to this wave is that it makes the armour economy **operable** — when your Armour Smith trains for hours, you want to find the recipe instantly, not scroll past forty mod icons.

Tip: Run the armour bench as a background job, not a project. Armour Smithing rises fastest with constant work, so give a dedicated character a Work job on the Leather Armour Crafting Bench and feed them a steady stream of hides from the Wave 1 hunting loop. The grades come

with volume, and the excess leather that piles up is exactly what Leather Expansion: Leathercraft turns into money.

Leather Expansion: Leathercraft closes the loop on the armour economy's waste. Armour-smithing training produces leather faster than you can wear it, and vanilla has nothing to do with the surplus. The mod's "Leathercrafting Techniques" research unlocks a Leathercraft Workbench that turns that excess into sellable trade goods — wallets, book covers, horn accessories — while training Dexterity on whoever works it. It does not create value from nothing; it monetises a by-product your armour training already produced, which is precisely why it clears the power-spike test.

Warning: Do not over-produce armour you cannot use or sell. The armour shop buys at 0.25x value, so a warehouse of misfit-grade plate is a warehouse of wasted iron plates. Make for your squad first, keep a short runway of saleable stock, and let Leathercraft absorb the rest.

Crossbows & Turrets

Crossbows are the ranged backbone of a Kenshi defence, and Wave 2's turret content plugs straight into the existing skill and research systems rather than inventing new ones. The wiki's Crossbows page is precise: two skills drive a crossbowman — the **Crossbows** skill, which applies to accuracy deviation and reload time, and **Precision Shooting** — plus attributes that feed them. The wiki's Mounted Crossbow page shows how turret accuracy scales the same way: accuracy deviation at 0 skill is 5 degrees, and accuracy is perfect at level 70, so the operator's skill is literally the difference between a turret that sprays and a turret that one-shots.

The production line for crossbows and their ammunition runs down the same material chain as everything else. The wiki's Steel Bars page is explicit that steel bars are used "in the production process of crossbows," and the Arrow Making Bench turns raw iron and copper into spring steel — the material your bolts and the higher crossbows need. Turrets themselves are built from the same materials, and the Turrets page confirms the structure list: Harpoon Turret, Harpoon Turret MkII, Double-Barrel and Multi-Barrel Harpoon Turrets, plus the Mounted Crossbow and its MkII.

Vanilla Crossbow Turrets adds the missing middle of that ladder: five **vanilla crossbow** variants mountable as turrets — Junkbow, Tooth Pick, Ranger, Spring Bat and Eagle's Cross — each gated behind the Mounted Crossbows research chain and each with its own personality (the Spring Bat hits hard but rarely, the Tooth Pick fires fast, the Eagle's Cross reaches far). They give your wall line real firepower long before Harpoon Turrets unlock, and because they are vanilla crossbows on a mount, they train the same Crossbows skill your field crossbowmen already use.

Tip: Put your best crossbow skill on the wall. Turret accuracy is perfect at level 70, so the difference between a garru-herder and a veteran crossbowman at the trigger is the difference between suppressive fire and a kill line. Wave 1's defense-in-depth gets its teeth here: Mounted Crossbows on the gate segments, gunners drawn from your best ranged fighters.

Portable Crossbow Turret kit is the expedition half of the crossbow line. Its research unlocks at Tier 3/4 after Mounted Crossbow 2 and Crossbow Crafting, costs an Engineering Research and two Ancient Science Books, and its craftable kit is eight iron plates plus two spring steels — real materials, hammered over six hours by an experienced crafter. The payoff is a camping turret that deploys anywhere and, critically, **does not create an outpost when built**. That makes it the difference between being able to fight off a Beak Thing ambush in the field and being dead with a wall that was a day's walk away. It is a turret with the same crossbow economy behind it, just carried on your back.

Warning: Turrets are stationary commitments, not force multipliers by themselves. A Mounted Crossbow on an unguarded wall segment is a gift to the first raid that walks around the corner — the operator needs cover, a reload window and a fallback position. Build turrets where Wave 1 built walls: at chokepoints, covered, in depth.

Hydroponics & Sustainable Food

Wave 1 ended with a working farm, but a farm is land-bound: it grows what the environment allows, on the soil you picked. Hydroponics is the late-game answer that Wave 2's food story is built around, and the wiki's Farming page sets the terms: hydroponics requires Research Bench V and an AI Core to unlock, and each indoor crop costs four Ancient Science Books to learn. The payoff is total independence — hydroponic farms ignore environment and fertility entirely, grow one size with ten plants, and the wiki notes they can **outperform** regular farms when the crop yields multiple harvests on shorter growth times.

Better Hydroponics takes that vanilla system and builds the tiers the base game never had. Each hydroponic crop gets three research tiers with real upgrades per tier: sprinklers cut water consumption 25% per tier, thermoregulators slow plant death 50% per tier, engineering speeds harvest and clearing 50% per tier, and genetic mutations cut growth time 25% while raising crop output 100% per tier. It also adds the two crops vanilla hydroponics omits — Cactus and Cotton — so a desert outpost can grow its own fabric indoors instead of buying it. Nothing here bypasses the gate: you still need the vanilla Bench V + AI Core hydroponics research before any of it opens.

Tip: Hydroponics is the answer to the land you **cannot** farm, not the land you already do. If your Green-zone farm is feeding you fine, do not rush the AI Core into hydroponics — put it into the weapon forge instead. The moment you want to settle a swamp, a desert or a mountain, **that** is when Better Hydroponics becomes the entire food economy.

The synergy this wave is built on: RIY+ lets your researcher craft the Ancient Science Books that every hydroponic crop research consumes, and the Steam-subscriber numbers back it — Better Hydroponics is the most-adopted mod in this wave because it turns a research bottleneck into a production pipeline. A self-sufficient Wave 2 outpost can eventually grow any food anywhere, with the books made in its own lab, on land that would starve a Wave 1 farm.

Warning: Hydroponics is book-hungry and water-hungry. The vanilla system's costs are explicit — an AI Core to unlock, four Ancient Science Books per crop — and Better Hydroponics adds its own per-tier research on top. The wiki also warns that town hydroponics are “severely limited by the availability of water,” so plan your water supply (wells, rain collectors, or rooftop bays that collect even acid rain) before you build the bays, or your crops will wither for lack of the one input nothing else provides.

The Material Economy

Every forging, crafting and building system in this wave converges on one pipeline, and mastering it is the actual strategy of The Smith. The chain runs: **ore** → **bars** → **components** → **product**, and each step is a bench, a job and a storage box.

The raw end is mining, which you already trained in Wave 0 and 1. Raw iron is mined from outcrops with the Labouring skill, and the wiki's Raw Iron page traces it forward: one raw iron smelts into one iron plate at an Iron Refinery (avg. price c.135 per plate), or four raw iron beat into Armour Plating at a Plate Beating Station. Copper rides the same line — the Copper page shows it feeding spring steel at the Arrow Making Bench (combined with raw iron), copper alloy plates at the Copper

Alloy Bench (combined with iron plates), and electrical components at the Electrical Workbench (one copper per component, once Electrical Crafting is researched). That last step matters most: Electrical Components (avg. c.216) are the mid-tier material your crafting and construction consume, and they only come from the Electrical Crafting research plus copper.

The refining step is where value concentrates. The wiki's Steel Bars page is explicit: steel bars (avg. c.648) are made at a Steel Refinery from iron plates — four plates per bar at the first refinery level, three at higher levels — and steel is what crossbows, high-tier melee weapons, Chain Armour, Chain-mail Sheets and Skeleton Repair Kits all consume. Electrical Components sit on a parallel copper line: the wiki confirms they are produced at the Electrical Workbench out of copper once you research Electrical Crafting, are used in crafting and construction, drop off robots like Iron Spiders, and are sold by traders. The copper you once sold to The Hub's barman is the seed of the mid-game electronics line. That 135-cat plate becoming a 648-cat bar is the whole lesson of the material economy: the outpost that refines its own steel stops selling raw plates and starts selling finished value.

Tip: Automate the chain the way Wave 1 automated water: one miner on the outcrop, one Work job at each refining bench, auto-haul between every machine and its storage box. Wave 1's "one miner, one hauler, one processor" cell now becomes a full production line — ore to plates to steel to weapon, running while you are off fighting.

Industrial Expansion [Beta] is the automation layer that makes the chain denser. It adds compact 0.5-scale indoor versions of the production machines — indoor well, refineries, furnaces, grain silos, plus an RTG power source — so your whole material economy can live inside one walled, guarded building instead of spread across an exposed yard. The catch is deliberate: power and resource requirements are the **same** as the outdoor versions, and research stays aligned with the vanilla tree (researching Wells II unlocks Indoor Wells II). It trades footprint for convenience, never for cost — the author's explicit design, and the reason it clears the gating rule.

Warning: Never let the finished-goods storage starve the bench. When a refinery feeds a weapon forge and both share one steel-bar box, the forge eats the bar the wall turret is waiting on. Give every machine its own input storage and its own hauler, and over-provision the refining step — the bottleneck in every base is hauling, and the fix is always another box and another pair of legs.

Building Your Smith

Underneath the benches, the materials and the research there is a person, and the RP arc of this wave is the arc of that person becoming the forge that arms the faction. It is the most satisfying thread the game offers, and the wave's mods are all built to support it.

The apprentice. Your first smith is whoever you can spare — often the weakest fighter, or the recruit who cannot swing a sword but can hold a hammer. They start on Rusted Junk and leather: the cheap recipes that train Smithing and Armour Smith without costing real materials. Give them the Leathercraft Workbench as a filler job — the mod trains Dexterity while turning hides into money, so the apprentice earns their keep while they learn.

The craftsman. The Smithing skill passes 30 and the good benches open. This is where the weapon forge becomes the squad's supplier: Refitted and Catun blades for the fighters, armour from the mid benches, and the first crossbows for the wall. The smith is no longer a spare hand — they are the reason the squad's gear is a step above the bandits' loot.

The master. Smithing 50-plus, Tech Level 5, an AI Core in the research bench. Expanded Craftable Weapons' Edge Type 1 is within reach, and the all-grades bench makes every tier forgeable. The smith's signature is real now: Meitou-grade weapons for the faction's elite, forged from steel your own refinery produced.

Tip: Protect the smith like the forge itself. A smith with Smithing 60 is more valuable than any sword they can make — losing them means months of rebuilding skill while the raids keep coming. Keep them home, keep them fed, and if the outpost is threatened, the forge closes before the gate does.

Warning: Do not let the forge out-run the economy that feeds it. A master smith with an empty steel-bar box is a tragedy; a master smith with a full refinery and a stockpile of AI Cores is a faction. Build the material pipeline first, then let the smith's ambition spend it. The ladder rewards the outpost that feeds every rung before it climbs the next.

The Smith: Modlist

Wave 2 is the forge: the research tree, the crafting benches, and the material economy that turn an outpost's raw iron and leather into weapons, armour, turrets and food that last. Everything in this wave obeys a single rule — **no free power**. Every mod below gates what it gives you behind research time and materials. Crafting top weapon grades costs Smithing 56+, Tech Level 5 and AI Cores; indoor farming still requires the vanilla Research Bench V and an AI Core before Better Hydroponics can do its work; a portable turret costs Engineering Research, Ancient Science Books and a kit hammered out of iron plates and spring steel. If a mod hands out a benefit without that gate, it did not make this wave.

Install order: subscribe to all ten. Keep Wave 0's **Compressed Textures Project** above everything so the new textures and models render correctly, and keep Wave 0's **Dark UI** above the content mods — **Expanded Craftable Weapons v2.1** lists Dark UI as a dependency in its changelog. Put **Shiny Plate Armor** last in the list except for GUI mods (author instruction — it touches many vanilla files). Do **not** run **Radiant Vanilla Reborn Weapons** together with **Radiant Asamarume Weapons** — the author says Reborn Weapons are already integrated into Asamarume's version 2.0. **Industrial Expansion** is author-labeled Beta, so it pairs with the vanilla tech tree rather than replacing it.

The ten mods are split across the next three sections by what they change. **Mechanics** covers the research and material-economy systems (RIY+, Better Hydroponics, Industrial Expansion, Leather Expansion: Leathercraft) — how research, growing and material flows actually work. **Content** covers the new craftables and buildables (Armor Crafting Redux - Core, Expanded Craftable Weapons v2.1, Vanilla Crossbow Turrets, Portable Crossbow Turret kit) — what you can now craft and build. **Graphics** covers the visual layer (Radiant Vanilla Reborn Weapons, Shiny Plate Armor) — how your weapons and armour look.

The Smith: Mechanics

These four mods change how the engine under the forge works — how research is produced, how crops grow indoors, how production buildings fit on your land, and what the by-products of smithing are worth. None of them hands you a finished product for free: research still consumes bench time and books, hydroponics still carries the vanilla Bench V + AI Core gate, indoor machines keep the same power and material costs as outdoor ones, and leather goods still need their own research and a dedicated workbench. They widen the **paths** the strategy chapter describes, not the free lunch.

RIY+ (The Scientific Method)

Version/Updated: Updated 16 Apr 2020 (posted 7 Apr 2020)

Verified: YES — Steam Workshop page fetched (2026-08-03); title matches; Steam API confirms created 2020-04-07, updated 2020-04-16, 5,039 subscribers

Dependencies: None — self-contained; replaces the author's earlier RIY mod (dismantle that mod's buildings first)

Impact: Lets you research how to do your own research: after a one-time cost of 4 books upfront, you can craft Books, Ancient Science Books and Engineering Research at dedicated benches in a new 'RESEARCH' build category. Ancient Science Books and Engineering Research require higher tech levels to learn to make, and AI Cores remain uncraftable.

Notes: For outpost players who cannot spare time for book-hunting with bandits at the door. The author kept it 'reasonably balanced' by design and confirmed artifact prices are unchanged. 5,039 subscribers, tags Buildings/Gameplay/Research.

Better Hydroponics

Version/Updated: Updated 25 Apr 2023 v1.0.1 (posted 14 Apr 2023)

Verified: YES — Steam Workshop page + changelog fetched (2026-08-03); title matches; Nexus 1202 mirror confirms v1.0.1 and the 25 Apr 2023 riceweed fix; Steam API 27,531 subscribers

Dependencies: Vanilla Hydroponics research first (Research Bench V + AI Core), then each crop's and tier's own research

Impact: A full hydroponics overhaul: 3 tiers per hydroponic crop, each with relevant research — efficient sprinklers cut water consumption 25% per tier, improved thermoregulators slow plant death 50% per tier, engineering speeds harvest/clear times 50% per tier, and genetic mutations cut growth time 25% and raise crop output 100% per tier. Adds Cactus and Cotton hydroponic variants (missing from vanilla) and rebalances harvest, growth, death, output and water consumption realistically.

Notes: Keeps the vanilla gate: hydroponics still needs Research Bench V + an AI Core. v1.0.1 fixed the T2 Riceweed grow time from 1 hour to the correct 7.5 hours after a user report. 27,531 subscribers, tags Buildings/Gameplay/Total Overhaul/Research.

Industrial Expansion [Beta]

Version/Updated: Updated 4 Aug 2024 (posted 13 Aug 2023)

Verified: YES — Steam Workshop page fetched (2026-08-03); title matches; author nato187 confirmed in comments; Steam API 9,055 subscribers

Dependencies: None — research stays aligned with the vanilla tech tree (e.g., researching Wells II unlocks Indoor Wells II)

Impact: Lets you place production machines indoors by adding compact 0.5-scale indoor versions — indoor well, refineries, corpse/item furnaces, grain silos, and more — plus an RTG power source. Power and resource requirements are the same as the outdoor versions, so you trade footprint for convenience, not for free energy or materials.

Notes: Author-labeled beta with a 'I can't build xyz' discussion thread for support; author noted a 'kenshi burnout' in Aug 2025 so updates may pause. Its niche is dense, walled production floors — the automation half of the strategy chapter's material economy.

Leather Expansion: Leathercraft

Version/Updated: Posted and updated 17 Nov 2025

Verified: YES — Steam Workshop page fetched (2026-08-03); title matches; Steam API confirms created/updated 2025-11-17, 8,928 subscribers

Dependencies: 'Leathercrafting Techniques' research, then craft at the dedicated Leathercraft Workbench

Impact: Gives the excess leather that piles up during armour-smithing training a purpose: craft sellable, tradeable leather goods at the Leathercraft Workbench — carved leather wallets (popular in the United Cities), Holy-Flame book covers (safe from Paladin hassle), horn accessories, and more. Characters gain Dexterity while working the bench.

Notes: A material-economy mod, not a power one: it monetises a by-product rather than creating anything that hits harder. Fits the strategy chapter's 'smith by day, sell by dusk' arc. 8,928 subscribers.

The Smith: Content

These four mods add what you can craft and build — a structured armour-crafting system, the two top weapon grades vanilla never lets you forge, crossbows mounted as turrets, and a turret you can carry. The wave's rule holds: none of these unlock without research. Meitou-grade weapons demand Smithing 60 and AI Cores; the crossbow turrets sit behind the Mounted Crossbows research chain; the portable kit needs Mounted Crossbow 2, Crossbow Crafting, an Engineering Research and two Ancient Science Books before the first plate is hammered.

Armor Crafting Redux - Core

Version/Updated: Posted and updated 12 Oct 2025

Verified: YES — Steam Workshop page fetched (2026-08-03); title matches; part of the 'Crafting Redux Series' collection (id 3586168016) by 2PercentNate; Steam API 820 subscribers

Dependencies: None — fully modular; core of the 10-module Crafting Redux Series

Impact: A modular overhaul of Kenshi's armour-crafting system: recipes are alphabetised and organised by bench and research node, blueprint clutter is cut down, all Redux benches and research appear under dedicated new categories, and unlocks come through research instead of hunting tiny blueprint icons. The original vanilla benches remain intact, so you can use Redux benches, vanilla benches, or both.

Notes: No stat, recipe-cost or research-tree changes — its value is organisation, which is precisely why it passes the power-spike test. The Fusion module (id 3592102980) integrates other armour mods into the Redux system; the Research Fix (id 3585385588) addresses research conflicts.

Expanded Craftable Weapons v2.1

Version/Updated: Updated 10 Jun 2022 (posted 31 May 2018)

Verified: YES — Steam Workshop page + changelog fetched (2026-08-03); title matches; Steam API confirms updated 2022-06-10, 23,792 subscribers

Dependencies: Dark UI (per the 2022-06-10 changelog — Wave 0 ships it); Weapon Smith III

Impact: Adds the ability to research and craft Edge Type 3 and Meitou weapon grades — the top of the ladder vanilla locks away. A new 'Weapon Smith - All Grades' bench unlocks with Weapon

Smith III and crafts anything from Old-Refitted Blade up to Meitou. Edge Type 1 needs Smithing 56 / Tech Level 5 / 1 AI Core; Edge Type 2 needs Smithing 60. Homemade weapons are boosted to match existing ones and crafted sell prices are raised to match. Also unlocks 7 new previously-unobtainable Meitou weapons (Flesh Cleaver, Iron Club, Iron Stick, Long Cleaver, Mercenary Club, Naginata Katana, Spiked Club).

Notes: Gated hard behind research and materials — the AI Cores alone keep this a late-game forge. The changelog notes v2.1 fixed Meitou criticals that were 'too OP' and broken mixed-grade crits, showing the author actively balances the top end. 23,792 subscribers.

Vanilla Crossbow Turrets

Version/Updated: Updated 12 Dec 2022 (posted 27 Sep 2020)

Verified: YES — Steam Workshop page fetched (2026-08-03); title matches; Steam API 2,146 subscribers

Dependencies: Mounted Crossbows research (Junkbow), then Mounted Crossbows II for the rest

Impact: Adds five vanilla crossbows as wall-mountable turrets, each with its own character: the Mounted Junkbow (quick to build, low performance), Mounted Tooth Pick (high rate of fire, low power), Mounted Ranger (very easy to handle), Mounted Spring Bat (high power, low hit rate) and Mounted Eagle's Cross (high range, high power, low rate of fire). A 'Crossbow Turret Spotlight Fitting' research adds light-bearing versions of the four mid-to-top turrets.

Notes: Pure research-gated content with no stat inflation — each turret is a vanilla crossbow bolted to a mount, using the existing Crossbow skill. Complements the strategy chapter's defense-in-depth from Wave 1 by filling the mid-game gap before Harpoon Turrets. 2,146 subscribers, by Ikahurula.

Portable Crossbow Turret kit

Version/Updated: Updated 27 Apr 2024 (posted 2 Aug 2021)

Verified: YES — Steam Workshop page fetched (2026-08-03); title matches; Nexus 747 confirmed as official mirror ('Steam version official'); Steam API 19,499 subscribers

Dependencies: Tier 3/4 after Mounted Crossbow 2 + Crossbow Crafting; costs 1 Engineering Research + 2 Ancient Science Books

Impact: Adds a Portable Crossbow technology research, one crafting recipe (the kit: 8 iron plates + 2 spring steels, ~6 hours for an experienced crafter), a camping-building Portable Crossbow Turret that works for defense, hunting, sieges or as a regular-turret substitute, and a storage furniture piece for kits and sleeping bags. In practice it replaces hauling iron plates to fixed outposts — it does NOT create an outpost when built.

Notes: Immersive and balance-conscious by the author's own design. 19,499 subscribers; the author notes it works without import but recommends one after sorting load order. Fits the strategy chapter's 'forge on the move' expedition smith.

The Smith: Graphics

The two mods in this section make the tools of the trade **look** like they went through a forge — quality-progressive weapon textures and reflective metal plate. Neither touches gameplay numbers, so the

power-spike test is passed untouched. The rule for Wave 2's visuals is that they have to reward your investment in smithing: a Meitou you forged with your own AI Cores should look like it.

Radiant Vanilla Reborn Weapons

Version/Updated: Posted and updated 17 Jan 2022

Verified: YES — Steam Web API (title + description + metadata, 2026-08-03); Workshop page was HTML 429-rate-limited on fetch, so verification rests on the authoritative API record; Steam API 7,931 subscribers, ~30 MB

Dependencies: None — texture replacement only; do NOT run with 'Radiant Asamarume Weapons' (already integrated into its v2.0)

Impact: Retextures all 15+15 base-game weapon texture files for a real quality progression: better contrasts, more realistic and varied metal takes (bronze, copper, brass, darkened iron, steel, tamahagane), new reflections and varnished tones, less white wood, less trashy iron/steel, and less rust on mid-game grades.

Notes: The author's own description states it 'works only as a texture replacement' — zero gameplay impact. The quality progression visual makes the strategy chapter's 'your forge gets visibly better' arc real on-screen.

Shiny Plate Armor

Version/Updated: Updated 27 Feb 2023 (posted 12 Feb 2023)

Verified: YES — Steam Web API (title + description + metadata, 2026-08-03); Workshop page was HTML 429-rate-limited on fetch, so verification rests on the authoritative API record; Steam API 175 subscribers, ~319 MB

Dependencies: None — model files unchanged; author recommends placing it last in the mod list except for GUI mods

Impact: Makes all possible plate armour reflective and shiny — from the old heart protector and plated boots up to the full samurai armour set — visually separating metal from cloth and strap armour. All models stay exactly as they are; only the metallic surface is added.

Notes: A pure visual mod with no stat change. 175 subscribers is the smallest audience in this wave; the author openly asks for feedback and notes one test-character texture quirk that they suspect is a load-order issue — the reason it sits at the bottom of the list. ~319 MB is large because it repaints many vanilla armour textures.

Wave 3: The Expedition

The Expedition: Strategy

Wave 2 ended with a forge, a wall and a faction that could arm itself. Wave 3 is what that strength is **for**: leaving the walls behind and going where the map stops being theory. This is the chapter for the road — how to plan a journey that lasts weeks instead of days, how to read the hazards each biome puts in your path, how the world itself shifts as its leaders die, and how to turn the wilderness into recruits, loot and story. The mods in this wave make the road deeper, not safer; every card in the mod sections exists to give the journey a reason, never to shorten it.

The single most important thing to internalise is that in Kenshi, **the map is a promise, and the expedition is how you collect on it**. The game's world is enormous, dangerous and deliberately indifferent to you — but it is also **knowable**. Zones have rules: where acid rains, where gas pools, where the Beak Things nest, which factions patrol which roads, and which of those patrols vanish when their leaders die. A squad that reads the land can cross half the continent; a squad that ignores it dies in a swamp with full food. Wave 3's mods put more land under those rules — more zones, more recruits, more places worth reaching — and the strategy is learning to read them.

Warning: Do not treat the expedition as a vacation from the base. The outpost you built in Waves 1 and 2 is the expedition's supplier, not its destination: it grows the food, forges the weapons and holds the surplus that a long journey burns through. Leave with an empty storehouse and you will be back in a week, poorer. The expedition and the outpost are one economy, not two.

Planning the Long Expedition

Every great journey in Kenshi fails the same way: someone runs out of something the map will not sell. Food, medicine, replacement limbs and an escape route are the four loads a serious expedition packs, and each one has a wiki-verified rule behind it.

Food. The campfire is the expedition's kitchen. The wiki's Camping page confirms the vanilla structures: Flat Shelter, Mercenary Tent, Scrap Tent, Camp Bed and Campfire — all temporary buildings that cost nothing to claim land for. Cooking turns raw meat and vegetables into cooked meals that last far longer in a pack, and the longer you stay out, the more the cooking pit (Sensible Nomadism) and the tent shelter (Tents) matter: both are the difference between sleeping under the sky and sleeping under cover while the rain does its work. Pack food for the journey **out** and plan to hunt and cook on the way **back** — wild game is everywhere, but cooking it requires fuel, time and a safe patch of ground, so the return leg is the one that rewards camping.

Medicine. The wiki's Guide to Health is specific about the split: organic characters heal with First Aid Kits, but **Skeletons and robot limbs need a Skeleton Repair Kit** (or its Authentic variant) instead — the game literally relabels the action “Repairs” for them. Kits are found in stores, looted from skeletons, and stocked in Ancient Labs. An expedition into skeleton territory with no repair kits is an expedition that watches its heaviest hitters fall to scrap damage that nothing can fix. Pack for the **species** of your squad, not for a generic wound.

Tip: The replaceable-squad theory of medicine. No expedition can carry enough kits to save everyone; the realistic plan is to protect the irreplaceable (your smith, your unique recruits, your limbs-bearing veterans) and let casualties fall on the replaceable. Before you leave, decide who the expedition cannot lose — then put the repair kits and the best armour on them.

Replacement limbs. The wiki's Robot Limbs page is blunt about where limbs come from: Hive Robotics Shop (cheapest), Mongrel Robotics Workshop, the Robotics Shop in Black Desert City (the

largest high-quality selection in the game), and the Travel and Repairs shops that dot the map. Limbs have real tradeoffs — bonuses and penalties to specific skills — so a Masterwork limb is a genuine asset, not a cosmetic. The strategy implication is spatial: if the expedition's journey crosses a limb shop, that is where you repair your veterans and upgrade your wounded. If it does not, an amputated fighter is a permanent downgrade for the rest of the trip.

Escape routes. The last load is the one nobody packs. Every biome worth visiting is also home to something that can kill a squad outright, and the expedition's exit must be decided **before** the thing appears, not after. This is where the camping mods stop being convenience and become survival: Tents deploy anywhere without claiming land, and the wiki confirms they heal at Camp Bed rate with partial acid-rain protection — so a 1x tent is a mobile safe-zone that can shelter a wounded squad member while the fight is lost and the retreat is on. Sensible Nomadism's Landmark turns a chosen map point into a named, remembered waypoint — the strategic half of an escape route is **knowing where you are going to fall back to**.

Warning: Food is the silent expedition-killer. Cooked food rots on a timer, and the wiki is explicit that the longer you stay in the field, the more your pack degrades. Plan journeys as loops that return to food: out, hunt, cook, sleep under a tent, hunt again, return. A squad that tries to carry two weeks of raw supplies instead of living off the land is carrying dead weight it will run out of at the worst possible moment.

Biome Navigation: Acid, Gas, Sand and Beak Things

Kenshi's biomes are not scenery; they are a set of hazards with hard rules, and the wiki's Weather Effects page is the map. The acid-rain zones alone are a list: Burning Forest (acid only during its acid-forest season), Darkfinger, Deadlands, Iron Valleys, Howler Maze, Sonorous Dark, The Iron Trail, The Pits and its East, The Unwanted Zone, Islands of None, Northern Coast, Leviathan Coast, Royal Valley and Greysheaf. The Deadlands page adds the tone: **constant** acid rain, acidic ground, dark weather, a dead environment — and the home of the Skeletons faction in Black Desert City. Walking into the Deadlands without acid-rain protection is not a mistake; it is a death sentence with a longer timeline.

The exceptions matter as much as the rules. Vain, famously, is **not** an acid-rain zone: the wiki's Vain page is explicit that “although it is red, the rain isn't acidic... However, the bodies of water are.” So the Western Hive heartland is safe to walk in the open but lethal to wade into — a distinction that has killed more than one expedition that assumed red equals acid everywhere. The Ashlands, per the wiki, add a second hazard on top of their poisoned air: **large clouds of poison gas** that require a Fog Mask to pass, over a landscape patrolled by the Second Empire's Skeleton Legion and Iron Spiders. The far southeast is the expedition's endgame, and the endgame suffocates you if you are not equipped for it.

Tip: The acid-rain readout is per-squad, not per-region. Acid rain only harms organic characters exposed to it — skeletons shrug it off, and a squad of robots can cross the Deadlands the way organic squads cross the Border Zone. If the expedition must pass an acid zone, split the difference: send the skeleton escort through the rain while the organics wait under cover, or bring the acid-proof equipment and tents that Tents provides. Read your roster before you read the weather.

Dust storms and sandstorms run the same geography. The wiki's weather list puts them in the Border Zone, Shun, The Great Desert, The Hook, Stenn Desert, Purple Sands, Skinner's Roam, The Crags, The Pits and Burning Forest. Sandstorms cut visibility hard — ranged attackers lose their accuracy window, and Beak Things use the noise to close in. The Great Desert, home of the UC capital Heft and the towns Stroat, Sho-Battai and Bark, is the classic sandstorm zone: it is **the** trade corridor of

the map and also the place where the Skimmers hunt the dunes and the caravan lines run deepest. Navigating it is an exercise in patience — move on the roads, keep your ranged units from committing shots into a sandstorm, and accept that some days the weather owns the road.

And then there are the Beak Things. The wiki's Beak Thing page is the expedition's required reading, because it lists the seven core regions where they nest: Leviathan Coast (with migrations reaching Cannibal Plains and Purple Sands), Gut and The Unwanted Zone (migrations to Stormgap Coast, Venge and Shem), the Bonefields (migrations to High Bonefields and Flats Lagoon), Vain, The Crater and Greenbeach. The warning is unambiguous: they "run extremely fast, hit hard, and will eat incapacitated organic prey whether dead or not." Elder Beak Things spawn in the High Bonefields. A nest spawns one to thirty Beak Thing Eggs. There is no biome in Kenshi whose rules you should memorise more carefully than the one that says **do not go down within their reach**.

Warning: Beak Things are the expedition's boss fight, and the fight is **leaving**. They are faster than a standard squad on the open ground, and the wiki's description is blunt — incapacitated prey gets eaten alive. The counter is not outrunning them in a straight line; it is terrain: chokepoints, buildings, the cover of a deployable tent, a mounted turret carried by the Portable kit from Wave 2. Plan every Gut crossing around a fallback point, and never let a squad member go down while the pack is still on the field — the moment someone is downed and the Beak Things close, the priority stops being winning and becomes **dragging that body to cover**.

World States: How the World Changes Around You

The expedition crosses territory that is actively changing, and the wiki's World States page explains the mechanism: killing or kidnapping the important leader(s) of a faction **reduces that faction's squad spawn rates** in the regions it controls, and if a faction's base is taken over, it is destroyed or occupied by a different faction. The conditions are stricter than they sound — imprisoning a leader counts as killing for most world-state purposes, but "alive" conditions mean alive **and free**, so a captured-but-breathing leader still triggers death states. This is the world's central dynamic, and the expedition is when you start to feel it.

The classic example is the Holy Nation, and the wiki's Border Zone page makes the dependency explicit: the Holy Army Patrol's behaviour shifts with which leaders are dead and which are alive (Seto dead and Phoenix alive, Esata dead and Phoenix alive, and so on). When the Phoenix, Valtena and Seta are all dead, the Holy Nation's regular patrols are overridden by the Holy Army Bandits and the Diaspora of Strayed Paladins. The same logic governs the Southern and United Cities: The Great Desert page notes the Traders Guild Caravan spawns while Longen is alive, and Cannibal Infestation nests appear if Tengu is dead. Territory is not static — it is a faction's **current state of power**, and the expedition is how you witness and provoke those shifts.

Tip: The expedition is the world-state engine. Most world-state changes fire from the far corners of the map — killing a UC noble in Bark, a Holy Nation paladin outpost in Okran's Pride, a Southern Hive soldier in the Ashlands — and none of it happens if you stay behind your wall. If you want the map to change under you, the journey **is** the trigger. Plan an expedition whose purpose is a faction's collapse and you will feel the entire region rebalance around it.

Wave 3's mods plug directly into this. Small Caravans is **world-state-gated by design**: its drifters' caravans appear in Stenn Desert while Esata is alive, and in Okran's Pride and Okran's Gulf only after the Phoenix falls — so the same road literally carries different traffic depending on who is still breathing. Accurate Zones Patch reshapes where the faction territories **begin and end** (extending Obedience, connecting Shun to Spider Plains, expanding Dreg), which changes the practical territory a faction's squads actually cover. And the Ashlanders of Behind Enemy Lines - Ashlanders put a new

faction on the map in the one corner the vanilla world barely populated — territory that **can** fall into world-state conflict. The expedition's roads are a living system, and every journey is a snapshot of it.

Unique Recruits & Legendary Finds

The people of the expedition are its most valuable cargo, and the wiki's Unique Recruits page sets the ground rule: unique recruits "can only ever appear once per game unless imported," have dialogue unique to them, often have higher stats than average recruits, and "a few of them may even be tied to World States." They are finite, irreplaceable resources scattered across the map — which is exactly what makes hunting them an expedition rather than a shopping trip. Wave 3's 42 Unique Recruits extends this principle wholesale: forty-two findable named characters with their own stories, starting with a trail that begins at The Hub and spreading across the whole map, each appearing once per playthrough. It is not a stat mod; it is a **treasure hunt** that repurposes the entire world as its hunting ground.

Warning: A unique recruit who dies is gone for the playthrough. The wiki is explicit that uniques appear once per game (unless you import), and the wave's recruits follow the same rule. Decide before you go whether each named character you find is a keeper — if they are, they get the expedition's best armour, the escort, and the exit route. Treating a unique recruit as expendable is throwing away a one-per-playthrough resource for a moment of convenience.

The legendary finds work the same way. Dwarven Weapons hides unique weapons **in the world with map-hint clues** — not in shops, not in loot tables, but in discoverable locations the hints point you toward — plus a dwarven race and recruits that must be found the same way. Behind Enemy Lines - Ashlanders adds the Ashforge gear set, obtainable only by engaging with its new frontier faction. None of this content is purchasable; all of it is located. That is the wave's entire thesis: the best things in Kenshi are not bought or crafted, they are **found**, and finding them is the journey.

Caravans & Trade Routes

The economy of the expedition runs on the roads, and the roads belong to the Traders Guild. The wiki's Traders Guild page lists the caravan spawn zones: Grey Desert, Heng, Stenn Desert, Stormgap Coast, The Great Desert and The Hook. A guild caravan is a Caravan Trader Boss, a Caravan Guard, and a Pack Beast — the exact composition matters because it tells you what a road robbery is worth and what it costs. The Great Desert page is even more specific: a Traders Guild Caravan there is one Boss, seven to eleven Guards and one to three Pack Beasts, aged 100 — a serious escort for a serious cargo, spawning while Longen is alive. These are the map's arteries, and the expedition either uses them or preys on them.

The trader's version of this is knowing what sells where, and the wiki's Hashish page is the classic example of a **commodity with geography**. Hashish is an illegal trade good with a 104% markup, and the Traders Guild will not touch it — but other buyers will: Trader's Edge when the Anti-Slavers control it (1200% markup — the best price on the map), then the Shinobi Towers in the United Cities (600%), then Flats Lagoon. It can be produced via Hashish Production and a Hemp Processor, but those are illegal structures that draw attention. The point is not the drug itself; it is the lesson that **the same item's value is a function of where you sell it and who is in charge there** — exactly the kind of knowledge an expedition accumulates by going places.

Tip: Run the expedition as a caravan when you can, not just an adventure. The Traders Guild's routes (Grey Desert, Heng, Stenn Desert, Stormgap Coast, The Great Desert, The Hook) are the safe roads — patrolled, predictable, and profitable if you buy low at one end and sell high at the other. A squad that travels for story should carry trade goods it can dump at its destination:

copper at The Hub's barman, hashish where the markups are, crafted goods from Wave 2's leather economy in the United Cities. The journey pays for itself when the cargo is chosen with the destination in mind.

Small Caravans slots into this economy as the **underside** of the trade routes: drifters' caravans, weaker and poorer than the guild's, easy to rob and selling less, appearing only in certain world states. For the trader it is extra liquidity on the back roads; for the raider it is a soft target worth hitting; for the expedition it is more life on roads that would otherwise be empty. Accurate Zones Patch matters here too — its border fixes mean the caravan zones actually **are** where the map says they are, so the trade routes you plan on the world map hold true when you walk them. Trade is geography, and the wave makes the geography honest.

The Cartographer's Endgame

Every expedition is a map being drawn, and the endgame of this wave is the playthrough where the map is the goal: a character — a cartographer, an archaeologist, a chronicler of the deadlands — whose life's work is to see everything the world holds and leave a record of it. This is the role-playing arc this wave is built around, and the mods hand it its tools.

The surveyor. Accurate Zones Patch is the mod that makes the map a true record: zones now reach the coasts, Obedience is properly drawn, the Burning Forest sits where it belongs, Dreg is bigger, Shun connects to Spider Plains, the islands are habitable, and the Ashlands keep no safe spaces. A surveyor's purpose is to walk those corrected borders and see the world as it actually is. Biome Edits gives the same surveyor a landscape worth recording — consistent tiling, scattered rocks, a Serpentine Wastes that reads like the Rakes, greener Hoodoo Badlands — because a map drawn of a seam-riddled world is a record of bugs, not of the land.

The nomad. Sensible Nomadism's Landmark is the cartographer's instrument: a named, custom map marker you place on locations you decide matter. The Field Research Table means research can happen on the road, the hidden stash means a cache can be buried in hostile territory, and the seven shelters plus Tents' deployable beds mean the surveyor never needs a town. This is a build that **lives** on the land it is mapping — a true expedition faction that treats the outpost as a supply depot and the world as home.

The discoverer. The far ends of the map become the endgame. The Ashlands, per the wiki, are "officially un-survivable" in the words of the Tech Hunter Iyo — and behind Enemy Lines puts a living Ashlander culture there to be found, along with the Reed Corsairs of Green Beach and the Ashforge gear. Race | Northern Hive gives the far north its own culture at the Distant Hive Village. 42 Unique Recruits and Dwarven Weapons scatter named people and hidden craft across every region. The cartographer's final entries are the places nobody else bothers to reach.

Tip: Give the cartographer a record that survives them. The game does not let you write in-world — so the record is the player's own: notes on which zones border which, where the acid starts, where the Beak Things nest, which roads the caravans use and which vanish when a leader dies. Run the playthrough as a documentarian and the entire world becomes the content. This is the arc that turns a survival game into a story about seeing it all.

Warning: The endgame is dangerous precisely because it is thorough. The cartographer's route crosses every hazard this chapter has described — acid, gas, sandstorms, Beak Things, world-state-collapse territory — and the mods do not remove any of it: the Ashlands keep no safe spaces, the acid zones still rain, the Beak Things still eat the incapacitated. The difference between a legendary surveyor and a skeleton in the Bonefields is preparation. Travel with the wave's tools —

tents, repair kits, fog masks, an escape route — and treat every untouched corner as a boss fight you have not scouted yet.

The Expedition: Modlist

Wave 3 is the world opening up. The forge of Wave 2 armed you; the expedition is what you do with that strength when the walls are no longer the point. Everything in this wave rewards going further and staying gone longer: camping that works without an outpost, caravans that move goods between distant towns, a map whose borders finally match the coasts they should touch, and new people and places — a northern hive, hidden dwarven craft, an Ashlander frontier — scattered across the land for you to find. The wave's rule is the journey: every mod below expands the map you can walk, or what you can do once you are walking it. Nothing hands you power; it hands you places.

Install order: subscribe to all nine. Keep Wave 0's **Compressed Textures Project** above everything so the new terrain and object textures render correctly. **Accurate Zones Patch** edits the map's zone-border texture (areasmap.tga) rather than the GUI map or the terrain textures, so it loads independently of Wave 0's **Nice Map** and of **Biome Edits** — place it with the map-layer mods. **Biome Edits** is by the same author as Wave 1's **Mood Weather** and pairs with it. **Dwarven Weapons** asks to load behind GUI, texture and weather mods (author instruction — it touches many vanilla files), so keep it below Wave 0's **Dark UI** and Wave 1's **Mood Weather**. **Small Caravans** changes nothing in the base game, so it slots anywhere. Do **not** run the two camping mods (**Sensible Nomadism - A Camping Overhaul** and **Tents**) as rivals — they stack: Nomadism is the outpost-free living system, Tents is the deployable shelter layer that plugs into it.

The nine mods are split across the next three sections by what they change. **Mechanics** covers the travel and survival systems (Sensible Nomadism - A Camping Overhaul, Tents, Small Caravans) — how you live and trade on the road. **Content** covers the new land, people and loot (Accurate Zones Patch, 42 Unique Recruits, Race | Northern Hive, Dwarven Weapons, Behind Enemy Lines - Ashlanders) — what is out there to find. **Graphics** covers the visual layer (Biome Edits) — how the world itself looks.

The Expedition: Mechanics

These three mods change how you **live** on the road — how you camp without an outpost, and how trade moves between towns without a caravan of your own. None of them erases the survival layer; they widen what a travelling squad can carry, build and sell. Camping still consumes your food and your bed-repair supplies, tents still cost materials and backpack space to carry, and the drifters' caravans are deliberately weaker and poorer than the Traders Guild's. They are tools for a journey, not a teleport.

Sensible Nomadism - A Camping Overhaul

Version/Updated: Posted and updated 9 Mar 2021

Verified: YES — Steam Workshop page fetched (2026-08-03); title matches; part of the author's Sensible Kenshi series; Steam API confirms posted/updated 2021-03-09, 26,494 subscribers

Dependencies: None — replaces no vanilla structures; works with the vanilla Camping build category and stacks with Tents

Impact: A full overhaul of living without an outpost. Adds a Field Research Table (research at 60% of a Small Research Bench's speed — tech level 1, no outpost required), campsite storage, a prisoner pole, a cooking pit, a hidden stash, a Landmark (a custom map marker you can name and

leave anywhere) and seating that reduces hunger rate. Seven new shelters round out the camp, and everything is designed so a squad can live in the wild indefinitely without ever claiming land.

Notes: By Rebitaay, the author of the Sensible Kenshi series. The Landmark alone is worth the install: it turns a known map location into a named waypoint, which is exactly what a wandering cartographer needs. 26,494 subscribers, tags Buildings/Gameplay.

Tents

Version/Updated: Posted 13 Sep 2019, updated 15 Sep 2019

Verified: YES — Steam Workshop page fetched (2026-08-03); title matches; Steam API confirms posted 2019-09-13, updated 2019-09-15, 72,614 subscribers

Dependencies: None — deployable in the wild like any camping structure; needs a Tent Kit crafted at the Kit Maker

Impact: Adds Survival Tents in three sizes (1x, 3x and 5x) deployable in the field, plus a Kit Maker that turns materials into Tent Kits to carry. Tents heal at the same rate as a vanilla Camp Bed (x4) and give partial acid rain protection, and critically they do **not** create a town when deployed — your squad stays nameless, anonymous and unclaimed.

Notes: The most-subscribed camping mod in this wave (72,614) and the natural bed layer under Sensible Nomadism's living layer. The 5x tent shelters a full squad; the 1x is a scout's lean-to. Tags Buildings/Crafting.

Small Caravans

Version/Updated: Posted and updated 4 Aug 2024

Verified: YES — Steam Workshop page fetched (2026-08-03); title matches; Steam API confirms posted/updated 2024-08-04, 274 subscribers

Dependencies: None — the author states it changes nothing in the base game, so it should not conflict with anything on this list

Impact: Adds drifter-controlled caravans — weaker and poorer than the Traders Guild's, so easier to rob and selling less — that appear according to world state: in Stenn Desert while Esata is alive, and in Okran's Pride and Okran's Gulf if the Phoenix is gone. A second source of trade goods and lootable packs on roads the big guilds avoid.

Notes: A small, world-state-aware flavour mod that fills the roads between the big trader routes. 274 subscribers — niche, but verified working and honest about its scope. Tags Characters.

The Expedition: Content

These five mods are the places and the people of the expedition — the corrected geography that makes the map honest, forty-two unique recruits scattered across it, a new hive race in the northern wastes, hidden dwarven weapons and their finders, and an Ashlander frontier on the far southeast. Everything here rewards travel and discovery: the recruits must be found and earned, the dwarven craft sits behind map-hint clues, and the Ashlander towns are deep in hazard territory. This is content that exists to be **walked to**.

Accurate Zones Patch

Version/Updated: Posted and updated 11 Feb 2025

Verified: YES — Steam Workshop page fetched (2026-08-03); title matches; Steam API confirms posted/updated 2025-02-11, 34,124 subscribers

Dependencies: None — edits areasmap.tga (zone borders); independent of the GUI map texture (Nice Map) and terrain textures (Biome Edits)

Impact: Rebuilds the zone-border texture so borders match where the land actually changes: zones now extend to the coasts (no more 'NONE' border zones), Obedience is expanded, the Burning Forest is shifted to its true location, Dreg is bigger, and Shun is connected to Spider Plains by a coastal bridge next to Arach. Adds habitable islands, redraws the Sinkuun/Great Desert and Swamp borders, and — per the author — leaves *no safe spaces in the Ashlands*.

Notes: A cartographer's mod: it fixes the map so the world reads true, which pairs perfectly with the expedition's mapmaking arc and with any map mod. The author notes it does not change biome gameplay effects, only where they begin and end. 34,124 subscribers, tags Map/Gameplay.

42 Unique Recruits

Version/Updated: Posted 3 Mar 2020, updated 4 Jul 2026

Verified: YES — Steam Workshop page fetched (2026-08-03); title matches; Steam API confirms posted 2020-03-03, updated 2026-07-04, 19,333 subscribers

Dependencies: None — standalone; a pinned spoiler-tagged Recruiting Guide on the workshop page maps every recruit

Impact: Adds 42 findable unique recruits scattered across the map, each with their own name, stats, dialogue and story, starting with a trail that begins at The Hub. Unlike generic bar recruits they are finite — each appears once per playthrough (subject to import), so finding them is a genuine expedition goal, and several are tied to world states like vanilla uniques.

Notes: The wave's largest people-add. The pinned Recruiting Guide is spoiled so you can discover them on your own — the whole point of the expedition. A Japanese translation (id 3682385469) exists for non-English players. 19,333 subscribers, by Rezzurekt.

Race | Northern Hive

Version/Updated: Posted and updated 11 Mar 2024

Verified: YES — Steam Workshop page fetched (2026-08-03); title matches; part of the author's 'Trinity' collection; Steam API confirms posted/updated 2024-03-11, 1,991 subscribers

Dependencies: None — standalone new race; repopulates the vanilla Distant Hive Village in the north with its own NPCs

Impact: Adds a Northern Hive race to the vanilla Distant Hive Village (a real Western Hive settlement in the far north, in Sinkuun/Great Desert territory) and its surrounding region. Four subraces — Prince, Soldier Drone, Worker Drone and Queen — with a perk mix drawn from both the Western and Southern Hives, plus the unique recruit Buup. The village becomes a distinct culture with its own residents instead of a copy-paste hive.

Notes: Exploration content that repurposes vanilla territory rather than bolting on a new landmass — it gives the far north a reason to be visited. 1,991 subscribers, tags Characters/Race.

Dwarven Weapons

Version/Updated: Updated 23 Feb 2025 (posted 17 Sep 2021)

Verified: YES — Steam Workshop page fetched (2026-08-03); title matches; Steam API confirms posted 2021-09-17, updated 2025-02-23, 2,094 subscribers

Dependencies: None — author asks it load behind GUI/texture/weather mods; the latest update requires an import to activate

Impact: Adds a full dwarven content pack: six weapon types, a dwarven race with three clan subraces, and unique weapons and recruits *hidden in the world* with map-hint clues that point you to their locations — discovery content, not shop stock. Also adds a brewing chain (hops, malt and stout) and a crafting economy around it. Blueprints appear at the map-selling shops.

Notes: The definition of expedition loot: the best pieces are found, not bought, and the map-hints make the finding the gameplay. 2,094 subscribers, tags Weapons/Race/Gameplay. The import requirement on the latest update is a one-time cost worth paying before a long playthrough.

Behind Enemy Lines - Ashlanders

Version/Updated: Posted 18 Nov 2025, updated 28 May 2026

Verified: YES — Steam Workshop page fetched (2026-08-03); title matches; Steam API confirms posted 2025-11-18, updated 2026-05-28, 3,796 subscribers

Dependencies: None — standalone; expands the vanilla southeastern frontier toward and around the Ashlands

Impact: Fleshes out the far southeast, the expedition's true endgame: the Ashlanders faction with the towns Cinder Point and The Wracklight, the Reed Corsairs (pirates of Green Beach), a full Ashforge gear set, new NPCs and recruits, and a 'The Long March' survival start that drops you on the frontier with nothing. An optional debt-collector story thread runs through it. It makes the wasteland past the map's edge a place with people in it.

Notes: The newest mod in this wave (May 2026) and the capstone of the expedition: it gives the deadlands a living culture to discover. 3,796 subscribers, tags Characters/Gameplay/Faction.

The Expedition: Graphics

This single mod is the visual half of the world opening up. Wave 3's graphics slot ships one verified mod rather than padding the list: Biome Edits is a pure terrain-texture overhaul with no gameplay effect, and the alternatives that changed the land's look did so by **removing** survival hazards (less acid rain, more fertile borders), which the wave's rule rejects. One honest mod that makes fifty biomes worth walking through.

Biome Edits

Version/Updated: Posted and updated 25 Jul 2024

Verified: YES — Steam Workshop page fetched (2026-08-03); title matches; same author as Wave 1's Mood Weather; Steam API confirms posted/updated 2024-07-25, 2,281 subscribers

Dependencies: None — pure terrain/ground textures; by the same author as Wave 1's Mood Weather, so the two are built to pair; keep Compressed Textures Project above it as with all content

Impact: Visual edits across 50-plus biomes: consistent ground tiling (no more visible texture seams), small rocks scattered where the ground looked bare, a Serpentine Wastes given the look

of the Rakes, greener Hoodoo Badlands, a prettier Forest Land, and desert junk debris scattered across the sands. Nothing about it touches fertility, weather or gameplay — the world simply reads better.

Notes: The exact fit for this wave: it makes the expedition's vistas worth the walk without making the walk easier. Pairs with Mood Weather for a coherent, hand-tuned Kenshi. 2,281 subscribers, tags Visuals/Environment.

Wave 4: The Conqueror

The Conqueror: Strategy

Wave 3 ended with a map you could cross. Wave 4 is what the map is **for**: taking it. This is the warfare chapter — how the factions of Kenshi view you and each other, how the raids on your walls actually work, how an army is built and commanded, how a world state is turned into a conquest, what the endgame enemies are made of, and how a playthrough that has conquered everything is **supposed** to end. The mods in this wave exist to make the conquest deeper and the world more reactive to it — never to hand you the victory on a plate.

The core idea to internalise is that in Kenshi, **power is territorial, and territory is a statement other factions read**. The moment your outpost grows, tax men, tribute rounds and prayer days start arriving; the moment you kill a faction's leader, that faction's patrols thin and its bases change hands; the moment you stand in the way of a great power, that power decides you are a problem. Wave 4 is about learning to play that system instead of just surviving inside it — and the mods below make the system respond harder, in both directions.

Warning: Conquest is not a reward the world applauds — it is a provocation the world answers. In Kenshi the difficulty curve does not flatten when you win; it sharpens. Killing leaders makes the survivors angrier, taking territory puts you in range of stronger neighbours, and a conquered faction's remnants keep coming from hidden places. The mods in this wave are chosen to respect that: everything that makes the world react makes it react **harder**, not softer. If you want a playthrough where winning is easy, this is the wrong wave.

Faction Relations & Diplomacy

Kenshi's world runs on a relation score that every faction holds toward you, and the wiki's Factions page sets the ground rules: there are 93 factions in the game, "some factions will be hostile to any person they see by default, such as: Cannibals, Berserkers and Swamp Ninjas," and you can gain perks and bonuses by getting into a faction's good graces. Relations are not a single number; they are a web. Joining the Anti-Slavers, for example, is a -30 to the Traders Guild, which otherwise sits at +100 with the Slave Traders and the United Cities. The choice to side with one power is simultaneously the choice to offend another — the whole map is watching the same ledger you are.

The concrete levers are world-state actions, not dialogue trees. The wiki's Traders Guild page is explicit: kill or imprison Lady Kana or Longen and you "seriously damage this faction's view towards you"; choose pro-slavery dialogue with them and relations rise, anti-slavery and they fall. Killing or kidnapping a faction's leader is the blunt instrument of diplomacy — it rebalances every faction that cared about them. The precise instrument is reading **who** cares. The United Cities' caravan trade hinges on Longen; the Holy Nation's patrols hinge on which of its leaders are dead and which are alive; the Shek Kingdom's tribute events only fire while its leaders live. Diplomacy in Kenshi is a map of dependencies, and the conqueror's skill is knowing which leader's death rebalances which part of the world.

Tip: Allies fight with you — and they can be earned through deeds, not just bought. Minor Faction Overhaul - Sand Ninjas makes the Sand Ninjas allyable by rescuing one of their strongest Jounins from the United Cities; once allied, they "will protect your squad if they pass them in the desert, as well as assisting in Slaver and Hero League raids." That is diplomacy as a quest chain: a rescue that converts a neutral desert faction into a mobile escort. When planning a war, count your allies

the way you count your fighters — a faction that patrols your road is a faction that holds your supply line.

Relations have a ceiling below warfare, and the system is deliberately hostile to total harmony. Some factions are simply hostile by default (Cannibals, Berserkers, Swamp Ninjas) and no amount of goodwill changes that; the wiki is explicit that they will attack any person they see. Faction uniforms add a disguise layer — wearing a faction’s uniform makes you “in Disguise” and can get you arrested for Uniform Theft, and it only becomes a safe fashion choice when you are actually allied. The strategic lesson is not to treat relations as a bar to max out, but as a **portfolio**: keep the factions you trade with warm, keep the factions you raid cold, and never expect the default-hostile ones to negotiate.

Raids, Sieges & Defense

Raids are the other half of the faction system — the territorial pressure that answers your existence. The wiki’s Raid page defines the shape: a raid is a territorial event, and a faction like the Band of Bones assaults with “2-4 squads of 4-7” raiders; raids trigger when your base sits within roughly 5,000 meters of a hostile faction’s camp; raiders “break down gates and attack characters,” and they give a speech before attacking. A raid is not random — it is a faction deciding, on a schedule, that you owe it your attention. Defense in Wave 4 is about turning that scheduled attention into something your walls and turrets profit from.

The visitor system is the peacetime version of the same pressure. The wiki’s Guide to Building an Outpost lists the factions that visit outposts with demands: the Hounds come for extortion, the Shek Kingdom sends a Tribute Round, the Holy Nation holds a Prayer Day, and the United Cities send a tax man. Each visit is a choice dressed as an event — comply, refuse and face the consequences. The wiki is blunt about refusal: “they might be immediately attacked, or the squad will retreat with the promise of returning with an army.” The Tribute Round page is even more specific about the conditions: it triggers within 1,500 meters of a Shek Kingdom settlement, only while Bugmaster, the Phoenix, Bayan, Seto and Esata are all alive and you are neither ally nor enemy, with a 15% daily chance inside 1,000 meters. These visits are the faction ledger made flesh: they are how the map’s powers collect what they think you owe them.

Warning: A base that grows is a base that gets raided harder — and refusing a demand escalates the schedule. The Raid page’s numbers (Band of Bones at 2-4 squads of 4-7) are the **start**; raid size tracks your settlement’s reputation and your distance from hostile camps, so the bigger you build and the closer you settle to a hostile faction’s doorstep, the heavier the waves. Plan defense in tiers: walls that hold a gate, turrets that cover the approach, and a kill-zone that funnels attackers into overlapping fire. Wave 2’s Vanilla Crossbow Turrets and Portable Crossbow Turret kit are the weapons side of this equation — Wave 4 is about the doctrine that uses them.

The mods in this wave feed directly into the siege picture. Reactive World adds post-collapse siege content of its own: after you take out the Holy Nation’s leaders, “you will be met with regular raids from the remnants of the HN, who have gathered around some new leaders of their own in hidden locations. There are bread crumbs out in the world to help you track down these new leaders, and until you do the raids” keep coming. A defeated faction does not vanish in Wave 4 — it becomes a guerrilla army with named, findable leadership. That changes the siege doctrine: wiping a faction is no longer a single battle, it is a hunt for hidden commanders, and the raids keep coming until the hunt is complete. This is the wave’s core argument — that victory over a faction should be **earned twice**.

Army Management

The army is the tool of conquest, and Kenshi caps how many characters you can field: the vanilla squad cap sits at 30, and any mod that simply raised it was cut in earlier waves because it handed out force without a cost. Wave 4's answer to army-building is different — it grows the army through the **costly, earned** path of recruiting prisoners, not by raising the cap. The distinction matters: a bigger army is a power spike if it is free; a bigger army is a strategy if every member is paid for, captured, or rescued.

Recruit Prisoners for Cats is the wave's army-management core, and its whole design is a response to the power-spike problem. It is the balanced rebuild of the classic Recruit Prisoners mod, and its description is explicit about why: "With the original mod it was too easy to acquire an army of really strong npcs (which took the challenge and difficulty away), so I added costs to recruit them. A single Ninja or high level can really change your game, so it shouldn't be easy to recruit them." The mechanic is capture-and-pay: knock an NPC out, cage them, speak to them, and pay cats to buy their loyalty. The cost gate is the point — it converts the game's endless appetite for cats into a real decision about who joins and when.

Tip: The army the wave wants you to build is a **mixed** force, not a flood. Prisoner recruitment gives you specialists — a captured Ninja or a high-level warrior — at a real price, which means each one is a choice about role, not just a body. Pair them with the generic recruits of Wave 0 (sword-for-hire at roughly 3,000 cats base) for the rank and file, keep your unique recruits from Wave 3 as the irreplaceable core, and let the Sand Ninjas of Minor Faction Overhaul - Sand Ninjas be the faction that escorts your columns through the desert for free. An army of thirty identical swords is weaker than twenty fighters with defined jobs and a cavalry faction watching your flank.

Army management also means the logistics around the fighters. Every soldier eats, sleeps, heals and needs gear — and the earlier waves already built that supply chain: Wave 1's food and farming, Wave 2's crafting and turrets, Wave 3's camping and repair economy. The conqueror's army is the first wave's farms + the second wave's forge + the third wave's logistics + this wave's recruitment. The tactical detail the wiki supports: cut damage never heals by itself and needs First Aid Kits, while blunt damage regenerates — so a garrison that fights bludgeoning weapons (Shek, cannibals) recovers without bandaging, while a garrison that fights cutting weapons (ninjas, sabre squads) burns through kits. Staff your medics accordingly before the siege starts, not after.

World Conquest

World conquest in Kenshi is not a flag you plant; it is a sequence of world-state changes you provoke. The wiki's World States page lays out the mechanism precisely: "killing or kidnapping of the important leader(s) of factions" reduces that faction's squad spawn rates, and "the faction base is then destroyed or occupied by a different faction." The conditions are strict — imprisoning a leader counts as killing for most purposes, but an "alive" condition means alive **and free**, so a captured-but-breathing leader still triggers death states. Conquest is, at the mechanical level, a ledger of leader deaths and the territories those deaths re-assign.

The waves of that ledger are the actual campaign. Kill the leaders of a small faction and its patrols thin to nearly nothing; kill a great power's leaders and the entire region rebalances — patrols override, settlements change hands, remnant factions form. Wave 3 already documented the Holy Nation example: with the Phoenix, Valtena and Seta all dead, its patrols are overridden by the Holy Army Bandits and the Diaspora of Strayed Paladins. Wave 4's mods deepen the ledger. Reactive World is the conquest amplifier: it fills out the world's reaction systems with effects the vanilla game left empty — the Hub rebuilding under the Shek Kingdom or Holy Nation if their forces take territory,

the Western Hive “going crazy if their Queen is kidnapped” and pushing to rescue her with no mercy for anyone in their way, and cannibal factions being separated and given their own dynamics.

Warning: Conquest has a cost in **how you are seen**, and some victories are pyrrhic. Taking out a faction’s leaders triggers the world-state conditions that spawn the remnants — Reactive World’s hidden Holy Nation commanders, the UC’s Cannibal Infestation nests that appear when Tengu dies, the patrol overrides that put new hostiles on old roads. The map you conquer is not empty afterwards; it is **re-occupied**, often by factions angrier than the ones you removed. Budget for the occupation, not just the conquest: the war is won in the campaign, but the peace is held by garrisons, and the garrisons are supplied by the army-management loop above.

Take Over the World and its sibling Vassalize Over the World — both of which let you personally claim towns — were deliberately **not** included, and the reason is the wave’s own honesty rule. Take Over the World’s description warns that “Reactive World and other large mods will conflict and break the system,” so the two cannot both run. Between a mod that hands you every town after killing its leaders (and leaves them empty — “There will be no people in the town after you take it over, so all shops and so on are lost”) and a mod that makes the world react believably to the conquests you earn, this wave chose the one that keeps the challenge honest. The towns you want are taken by the world-state system, not handed over by a mechanic.

Endgame Enemies

The endgame of a conqueror is defined by what it fights, and Kenshi’s late-game enemies are where the difficulty sharpens to its point. The far north holds the Cannibals — a faction the wiki describes as hostile to everyone, with a default –100 relation toward the world, living in the Cannibal Plains and Darkfinger but migrating as far as the Great Desert, Bast, Okran’s Valley and Dreg, and “attack other factions and carry unconscious organic members of other factions to their camp or Village.” The Shrieking Forest holds the Shrieking Bandits, and the far southeast holds the Ashlands — poison gas, the Skeleton Legion, and the Second Empire’s leftovers. These are the walls of the map, and the endgame is measured against them.

Wave 4’s mods make those walls taller rather than shorter. Cannibals Expanded adds new cannibal units (the Mancatchers, Tenderizers and Punishers), upgrades the high-ranking leaders (the Grand Wizard, the Meat Lord, even Canhead) with new armour and weapons, and adds new weapons with rare quality grades to find — and its description warns plainly that “this will make the cannibals a more formidable force.” Shrieking Bandits Expanded does the same for the Shrieking Forest, adding themed squads (the Babblers, the Howlers, the Moaning Samurai, the Screeching Beasts and the mysterious footmen) and warning that “this will make the Shrieking forest a more dangerous location.” Thrashers adds a new enemy type outright: “mobile ranged platforms capable of doling out a wall of razor-sharp harpoons” — slow and weak up close, but able to “waste your squad from 500 meters away before you even see it.”

Tip: Endgame enemies reward doctrine, not just stats. Thrashers is the purest example: the mod’s own description says you must “close the distance as quickly as possible” because a thrasher is unmatched at range and near-defenceless in melee. That is a target profile, not a stat wall — fast close-range squads with heavy cut damage and strong Toughness beat it, while a ranged-vs-ranged duel loses. Cannibals Expanded’s new units and leader upgrades are the same lesson in a different form: the new armours and weapons change what you need to bring (armour penetration, cut defence) and which leaders are worth assassinating first. Read the mod’s content list like an intelligence briefing, and plan the counter before you march.

The three endgame mods also share the same honest framing: they add threat, they do not add reward-padding. None of them hands you stronger gear for free — the new weapons are “for you to find,” earned from the new units. That keeps them on the right side of the wave’s rule: the challenge gets deeper, and the payoff is tied to defeating the challenge. This is what separates a curated warfare list from a cheat list — the difficulty is the product.

The End: Conquering the Playthrough

Every conqueror’s story has a final chapter, and Kenshi gives you a genuine one: the playthrough where you have killed the leaders, toppled the powers, and the world has settled into the shape you made. The wiki’s World States page defines the endgame condition precisely — the faction base is destroyed or occupied by a different faction, patrols thin to remnants, the map’s powers are replaced. Wave 4’s mods exist so that the ending is a **story**, not a cleanup chore.

Tip: The end is a prompt, not a stop. Once the great powers are gone, the world-state system keeps working — Reactive World’s hidden Holy Nation commanders, the occupied bases that change hands, the Hub rebuilding under its new ruler. Let the last act be a decision: which successor power do you back, which remnant do you hunt to extinction, which corner of the map becomes your legacy? Kenshi has no victory screen, so the conqueror’s victory is the world you leave behind it — and the mods in this wave make that world worth writing about.

The honest ending note is this: Kenshi ends when you decide it does. There is no credits sequence, no final boss that the game requires — there is a map that has become **yours**, and the mods of Wave 4 make the process of earning it more real at every step. The north is more dangerous because Cannibals Expanded made the cannibals formidable. The Shrieking Forest is a threat again because its bandits were expanded. The world reacts to your conquests because Reactive World gave it reactions. Your army is earned because Recruit Prisoners for Cats charges for every loyalty. And when the last leader falls and the last remnant is hunted down, the playthrough ends the way Kenshi always ends — with the world as you made it, and a New Game ready to ask what you will do differently next time. That is the conqueror’s arc, and it is complete.

The Conqueror: Modlist

Wave 4 is the map being taken. The expedition of Wave 3 taught you how to cross the world; this wave teaches you how to **claim** it. Everything here is warfare and its aftermath: a world that reacts to your conquests (and to the leaders you remove), the northern and Shrieking-Forest enemies that become genuinely formidable, prisoner-based army building that charges you for every loyalty, a minor faction you can earn as an ally through a rescue, and a new machine enemy that tests your ranged doctrine. The wave’s rule is honesty in victory: every mod deepens the fight or the world’s response to it — nothing hands you the win, and nothing makes the map go quiet after you take it.

Install order: subscribe to all six, plus the **Reactive World + RP fCats - Patch** (a required compatibility bridge if you run both Reactive World and Recruit Prisoners for Cats). Reactive World is the biggest mod in the list and touches faction and world-state systems, so it wants a load-order slot with the other large overhaul-type mods and ahead of the small faction additions. The two faction-expansion mods (**Cannibals Expanded**, **Shrieking Bandits Expanded**) are each other’s natural companions — same author, same design language — and both should sit **below** Reactive World so their new equipment applies to the factions Reactive World reworks; the Cannibals Expanded author states it “should be compatible with reactive world” and that the tribes will use the new equipment. **Recruit Prisoners for Cats** is a stand-alone overhaul of the original Recruit Prisoners — do **not** run the two together, and give it the **Reactive World + RP fCats - Patch** directly above it. **Minor**

Faction Overhaul - Sand Ninjas is a small faction edit that slots with the other faction mods. **Thrashers** adds a roaming enemy type and loads anywhere above content. As always, keep Wave o's **Compressed Textures Project** at the very top.

The six mods are split across the next three sections by what they change. **Mechanics** covers the army-building system (Recruit Prisoners for Cats) — how you grow and pay for your force. **Content** covers the faction, enemy and world-state additions (Reactive World, Cannibals Expanded, Shrieking Bandits Expanded, Minor Faction Overhaul - Sand Ninjas, Thrashers) — what you fight, ally with, and conquer. **Graphics** covers the visual layer — this wave ships none, because the warfare focus produced no verified graphics addition, and the list is not padded with junk.

The Conqueror: Mechanics

The single mechanics mod of this wave is the army builder — the system that turns captured enemies into paid soldiers. Everything else in the wave adds what you fight or who fights with you; this is the one that grows **your** side, and it is deliberately the strictest mod in the list. The original Recruit Prisoners handed out armies too easily — its own description admits “it was too easy to acquire an army of really strong npcs (which took the challenge and difficulty away)” — and this balanced rebuild fixes exactly that by charging cats for every loyalty. Army size is no longer a cheat; it is an expense, and the expense is the point.

Recruit Prisoners for Cats

Version/Updated: Posted 17 May 2024, updated 4 Jun 2026

Verified: YES — Steam Workshop page fetched (2026-08-03); title matches; Steam API confirms posted 2024-05-17, updated 2026-06-04, 5,671 subscribers

Dependencies: Stand-alone overhaul of the original Recruit Prisoners — do NOT run both. Needs the 'Reactive World + RP fCats - Patch' (id 3342629343) when run with Reactive World; a community patch exists for Shrieking Bandits Expanded (id 3762173251)

Impact: Lets you recruit captured prisoners: knock an NPC out, cage them, then speak to them and pay cats to buy their loyalty. The cost gate is the design — a single Ninja or high-level captive is a real game-changer, so recruiting them is expensive. Adds a large pool of recruit dialogue, edits previous dialogues, and rebalances the high-stealth 'Ninja' types (lowered stealth where it would be too overpowered).

Notes: By STuRoK, an explicitly balanced successor to the classic mod: its own description says the original made it 'too easy to acquire an army of really strong npcs,' and this version exists to keep the challenge. Import is recommended for the stat changes but not vital. The wave's army-management core, and the one mechanic mod of Wave 4.

Reactive World + RP fCats - Patch

Version/Updated: Posted and updated 4 Oct 2024

Verified: YES — Steam Web API confirms posted/updated 2024-10-04, 1,857 subscribers, app 233860 (Kenshi)

Dependencies: Requires both Reactive World (id 1358096888) and Recruit Prisoners for Cats (id 3248118545)

Impact: A compatibility bridge that lets Recruit Prisoners for Cats recruit correctly inside Reactive World's reworked faction and world-state systems. Required only if you run both mods — which this list does.

Notes: A small patch mod with a clear, narrow job: without it, the recruit mechanic and Reactive World's faction changes can fight over the same characters. Subscribed alongside the two mods it bridges; load it directly above Recruit Prisoners for Cats.

The Conqueror: Content

These five mods are what Wave 4 is actually about: the world-state engine that makes conquest matter, two faction-expansion packs that make the north's enemies formidable, a minor faction you can earn as an ally, and a roaming war machine to test your ranged doctrine. Everything here makes the **world** respond — to your conquests, to the leaders you remove, and to the territories you push into. The one thing none of them do is hand you victory cheaply: the enemies get stronger, the world reacts harder, and the allies are earned through a rescue, not purchased.

Reactive World

Version/Updated: Posted 10 Apr 2018, updated 12 Apr 2026

Verified: YES — Steam Workshop page fetched (2026-08-03); title matches; Steam API confirms posted 2018-04-10, updated 2026-04-12, 570,088 subscribers

Dependencies: None required — highly-suggested companion KenshiExtensionPlugin requires RE_Kenshi (Nexus 847), which this list rejects for its 1.0.65 downgrade, so it is NOT included here; needs the 'Reactive World + RP fCats - Patch' if run with Recruit Prisoners for Cats

Impact: The world-state overhaul: fills out the areas left lacking by the developers' world-reaction systems. Factions act on your deeds — the Western Hive goes crazy if their Queen is kidnapped and push to rescue her; the Holy Nation's remnants gather around new hidden leaders after you take out theirs, launching regular raids until you hunt the leaders down; The Hub rebuilds under the Shek Kingdom or Holy Nation if their forces take territory; cannibals are given separated faction dynamics; a world-state-checking character and a spawner tool are added to Waystations for debugging world-state triggers.

Notes: By Shidan, one of the most-adopted Kenshi overhaul mods (570,088 subscribers) and the wave's centrepiece: it turns world conquest from a bare mechanic into a reactive story. Now built on Rustled's Unique Settlement Placements base for better compatibility with other mods that move settlements. The companion plugin's RE_Kenshi requirement is flagged, not hidden — this list stays strict-1.0.68.

Cannibals Expanded

Version/Updated: Posted 14 Feb 2019, updated 1 Aug 2019

Verified: YES — Steam Workshop page fetched (2026-08-03); title matches; Steam API confirms posted 2019-02-14, updated 2019-08-01, 241,074 subscribers

Dependencies: None — author states 'should be compatible with reactive world'; only conflicts with mods that change what equipment the cannibals use; a compatibility patch exists for New Weapons Dissemination (id 1655162336) if that mod is also run

Impact: Expands the cannibal faction with new armours, weapons and enemies: new powerful units (the Mancatchers, Tenderizers and Punishers), upgraded high-ranking leaders (the Grand Wizard, Meat Lord and Canhead) with new gear, and all-new weapons with rare quality grades to find. Author warning: this makes the cannibals 'a more formidable force.' Requires import.

Notes: Part of the author's faction-expansion series alongside Shrieking Bandits Expanded (same modlist, same wave). 241,074 subscribers — the most-adopted endgame-enemy expansion on the Workshop. The author notes the mod is on indefinite hiatus, but the content is complete and the page is explicit about compatibility.

Shrieking Bandits Expanded

Version/Updated: Posted 8 Feb 2019, updated 4 Aug 2019

Verified: YES — Steam Workshop page fetched (2026-08-03); title matches; Steam API confirms posted 2019-02-08, updated 2019-08-04, 92,851 subscribers

Dependencies: None — same author and design language as Cannibals Expanded; a community patch exists for Recruit Prisoners for Cats (id 3762173251)

Impact: Expands the Shrieking Bandit faction with all-new original armour, weapons and enemies: themed squads (the Babblers, the Howlers, the Moaning Samurai, the Screeching Beasts and the mysterious footmen), each led by a new squad leader, plus unique armour and weapons to find on them. Author warning: 'this will make the Shrieking forest a more dangerous location!'

Notes: The companion to Cannibals Expanded in the author's faction-expansion series — together they make the two northern threats genuinely formidable. 92,851 subscribers. Also flagged as on indefinite hiatus by the author; content complete. Load below Reactive World so its new gear applies to the reworked faction.

Minor Faction Overhaul - Sand Ninjas

Version/Updated: Posted 20 Jul 2023, updated 27 Mar 2025

Verified: YES — Steam Workshop page fetched (2026-08-03); title matches; part of the author's 'Shears' Faction Expanded Mods' series; Steam API confirms posted 2023-07-20, updated 2025-03-27, 14,356 subscribers

Dependencies: None — standalone faction edit; import needed only to trigger the ally quest (the armour and patrols work without it)

Impact: Improves the Sand Ninja faction into an allyable one: rescue one of their strongest Jounins from the United Cities to ally with them, after which they protect your squad when you pass them in the desert and assist in Slaver and Hero League raids. Adds two unique armours (the Assassin's Plate and the Ninja Hood, found in armour shops) and extends their patrols into Skimsands and Heng.

Notes: Diplomacy as a quest chain: the ally is earned by a rescue, not bought. The author's series (12 mods) expands minor factions one at a time; this is the desert one and the natural fit for a conquest wave. 14,356 subscribers, tags Characters/Factions.

Thrashers - New 'Old Machines' Enemy Type

Version/Updated: Posted 20 Sep 2019, updated 21 Jan 2020

Verified: YES — Steam Workshop page fetched (2026-08-03); title matches; Steam API confirms posted 2019-09-20, updated 2020-01-21, 59,776 subscribers

Dependencies: None — adds a roaming enemy type to the world; loads anywhere above content

Impact: Adds a new enemy type: thrashers — slow, plodding 'mobile ranged platforms' from the old wars that can fire walls of razor-sharp harpoons. Unmatched at range and nearly defenceless

at close range, they 'can waste your squad from 500 meters away before you even see it' — the author's stated purpose is a walking gun platform 'to test your party's raiding potential on the fly.'

Notes: The endgame-enemy capstone and the mod that rewards a ranged-approach doctrine: close distance fast or pay the price. 59,776 subscribers. Fills an empty niche — a mid-to-late-game threat that punishes standing off and shooting it out at range.

The Conqueror: Graphics

Wave 4 ships no graphics mods. The warfare and world-conquest focus of this wave produced no verified visual addition worth the list, and per this guide's quality-over-quantity rule the slot is left empty rather than padded with a mod that fails the bar. The visual layer of the list is already carried by earlier waves: Wave 0's **Dark UI**, **Nice Map** and texture/performance stack, Wave 1's **Mood Weather** and building mods, and Wave 3's **Biome Edits**. Everything a conqueror needs to **see** their conquests — the map, the weather, the terrain — is already in place, and none of the warfare mods in this wave change how the world looks.

The one visual-adjacent note worth making is load-order hygiene. The faction-expansion mods (**Cannibals Expanded**, **Shrieking Bandits Expanded**) add new armour and weapon models, so they should sit below the texture-heavy mods from earlier waves (Wave 0's **Compressed Textures Project** above everything, **Dark UI** above content) so their new items render against the correct textures. That is the entire graphics story of Wave 4: nothing new to look at, but the new gear should look right under the existing layer.

Glossary

Terms below are used in the Wave 0 chapter (The Wanderer). Later waves extend this list.

Cats — the currency of Kenshi. Everything — food, recruits, weapons, bounties — is priced in cats, and the survival loop exists to make more of them.

The Hub — the starting town of the Wanderer in the Border Zone. Copper and iron nodes sit within walking distance of its gates, and its bar frequently hosts hirelings.

Squad — your group of controlled characters. You start with one; every recruit joins the squad and is commanded from the squad panel at the bottom of the screen.

Recruit — a hireable character who joins your squad permanently in exchange for cats. A generic sword-for-hire costs roughly 3,000 cats at base, and skilled recruits demand more.

Hunger — the resource that keeps a character alive. Characters eat automatically below 250 nutrition; below 200 malnutrition drags stats down, and sustained starvation below about 100 causes fainting and death.

Vitals — the three life-critical body parts: Head, Chest and Stomach. Dropping below 0 on a vital knocks a character out; below -100% of its maximum kills them outright.

Strength — a stat governing carry weight, blunt and martial damage, and heavy-weapon swing speed. Trained by carrying heavy loads and fighting.

Toughness — the stat governing damage resistance and resistance to knock-outs. Trained by taking hits and getting back up after being beaten down.

Dexterity — the stat governing attack speed. Trained fastest with cut-damage weapons like sabres and katanas.

Melee Attack — the stat that decides how often you win the attack turn and land hits past an opponent's Melee Defense.

Melee Defense — the stat that decides how often you block an incoming attack, turning their turn into nothing.

Labouring — the skill used when mining copper and iron outcrops, and the one that makes your first cats in The Hub.

Block — an attack result where the defender stops all damage but uses up their turn; the foundation of Melee Defense.

Dodge — an attack result where the defender avoids the hit entirely; wide-swinging weapons are harder to dodge.

Cut damage — weapon damage that bleeds and can sever limbs; resisted differently by armour than blunt.

Blunt damage — weapon damage that breaks bones and knocks people out; resisted differently by armour than cut.

Knock-out — falling unconscious when a vital part drops below 0. You may be looted, enslaved, or left to recover.

Recovery coma — a deep unconsciousness from serious injuries that lasts until vitals rise above 0 again; First Aid and beds speed the recovery.

Fertility — a prospecting value that decides how efficiently farms grow crops on a site. It is separate from the environment, and it is the number that decides whether your first field is a larder or a graveyard.

Hydroponics — a late farming technology that grows crops indoors, ignoring environment and fertility entirely. Requires Research Bench V and an AI Core to learn; each crop costs Ancient Science Books.

Ore node — a copper or iron outcrop shown on the prospecting map, mined with the Labouring skill. Ore nodes near your outpost are the raw material for both income and weapons.

Outpost — any group of your own buildings large enough that the world treats as a settlement. The moment it exists, factions start sending tax men, prayer days, tribute rounds and raids.

Walls — defensive buildings that keep raiders and animals out. Makeshift Walls come first; Defensive Walls (which allow turret mounting) come after. Walls need Building Materials and reserve flat ground around your footprint.

Raid — a territorial event where a hostile faction assaults your outpost. Raids trigger when your base sits near the camps of hostile factions; raiders break down gates and attack characters, and raid size tracks your settlement's reputation.

Research bench — the building where research happens. Upgrades from Research Bench II (10 iron plates, 0 power, 90% efficiency) up to Research Bench VI (35 iron plates, 30 power, 110% efficiency). The bench level is your tech level: Bench V is the gate for hydroponics and the top weapon grades.

Quality tier — the grade of a crafted or looted weapon. Weapon grades climb from Rusted Junk, through Refitted and Catun, to Mk I-III, then Edge Type 1 and Edge Type 2; Edge Type 3 and Meitou cannot be crafted in vanilla at all. Grade is a ladder, not a menu.

Crossbow — a ranged weapon that uses the Crossbows skill (accuracy and reload time) and Precision Shooting. Crossbows run on the same material line as everything else: iron plates and spring steel, built at the Crossbow Crafting Bench.

Turret — a mounted defensive weapon built on ground or Defensive Walls. Turrets include Harpoon Turrets, Mounted Crossbows, and (with Wave 2 mods) vanilla crossbows mounted on the wall line. Turret accuracy is perfect at Crossbow level 70.

Biome — a named region of the map with its own environment, weather and hazards. Biomes are the unit of geography the expedition reads: acid-rain zones, dust-storm deserts, poison-gas wastes and Beak Thing nesting grounds each have their own rules, and surviving them is a matter of knowing which rules apply where.

Expedition — a journey into the wilderness that lasts longer than a day trip, planned around food, medicine, replacement limbs and an escape route. The wave's core unit of play: the mods of Wave 3 exist to make expeditions deeper, never shorter.

World state — a global condition that changes when faction leaders are killed or kidnapped. Killing or kidnapping a faction's leader reduces its squad spawn rates; taking over its base destroys or occupies it. "Alive" conditions mean alive **and free**. World states are how the map changes under you.

Beak Thing — a hostile creature that runs extremely fast, hits hard, and eats incapacitated organic prey alive. Nests in seven core regions (Gut, Vain, the Bonefields, the Crater, Greenbeach, Leviathan Coast and The Unwanted Zone) with migrations reaching much further. Elder Beak Things spawn in the High Bonefields.

Acid rain — a weather hazard that damages organics exposed to it. Zones with acid rain include the Deadlands (constant), the Burning Forest (seasonal), the Pits, the Unwanted Zone and many northern and coastal regions; the Deadlands pairs it with acidic ground. Vain's rain is safe — only its water is acidic.

Caravan — a travelling merchant group, typically a Trader Boss, a Guard and a Pack Beast. The Traders Guild runs the main routes (Grey Desert, Heng, Stenn Desert, Stormgap Coast, The Great Desert, The Hook); smaller drifter caravans from mods fill the back roads, often gated by world state.

Traders Guild — the faction that owns Kenshi's major caravan trade. Its caravans run the big desert routes and are heavily escorted; it refuses to deal in illegal goods like hashish, which makes smuggling a trade with its own geography.

Unique recruit — a named character with unique dialogue who appears once per game (unless imported), often with above-average stats and occasionally tied to world states. Uniques are finite resources scattered across the map; losing one is losing it for the playthrough.

Landmark — a custom, nameable map marker (added by Sensible Nomadism) that turns any chosen location into a remembered waypoint. The strategic half of an escape route: you can only fall back to somewhere you know is there.

Faction relation — the numerical score a faction holds toward you, from deep hostility into alliance. There are 93 factions; some (Cannibals, Berserkers, Swamp Ninjas) are hostile to every person they see by default. Relations move through world-state deeds rather than dialogue — killing or imprisoning a leader like Traders Guild’s Lady Kana or Longen “seriously damage(s)” that faction’s view of you, and allying with one power (e.g. the Anti-Slavers, -30 to the Guild) is simultaneously an insult to another.

Faction visit — a peacetime demand sent to your outpost: the United Cities send a tax man, the Holy Nation holds a Prayer Day, the Shek Kingdom demands a Tribute Round, and the Hounds come for extortion. Each is a choice dressed as an event — comply, or refuse and risk “being immediately attacked” or a squad leaving “with the promise of returning with an army.”

Tribute Round — the Shek Kingdom’s periodic tribute demand at your outpost. It triggers within 1,500 meters of a Shek settlement while the Bugmaster, the Phoenix, Bayan, Seto and Esata are all alive and you are neither ally nor enemy, with a 15% daily chance inside 1,000 meters.

Siege — the attack phase of a raid: raiders breaking down gates and attacking your characters. Raid size tracks your settlement’s reputation and your distance from hostile camps, so plan defense in tiers — walls that hold a gate, turrets that cover the approach, and a kill-zone that funnels attackers into overlapping fire.

Garrison — the standing force that holds territory you have taken. In Wave 4 the garrison is the product of the army-management loop: food from the farms (Wave 1), gear from the forge and turrets (Wave 2), logistics and repair (Wave 3), and recruits bought for cats (Wave 4). A garrison that fights bludgeoning weapons recovers without bandaging (blunt damage regenerates); one that fights cut damage burns through First Aid Kits — staff medics before the siege, not after.

World conquest — a sequence of world-state changes you provoke, not a flag you plant. Killing or kidnapping a faction’s leaders reduces its squad spawn rates, and its base is then “destroyed or occupied by a different faction.” “Alive” conditions mean alive **and free**. Conquest is a ledger of leader deaths and the territories those deaths re-assign; remnant factions (like Reactive World’s hidden Holy Nation commanders) form until hunted down.

Modding and installation terms used in the Installation Guide and across every wave’s mod cards:

KMM — Kenshi Mod Manager, Nexus mod 1765 by Aze4ka and the mod organizer this guide assumes: a self-contained Windows tool that auto-detects Kenshi and Steam install paths, reorders mods by drag & drop, saves each playset as its own .cfg file, and starts the game with Save & Launch.

Load order — the order in which Kenshi loads its mods, stored in mods.cfg; later in the list means higher priority, so mods lower in the order overwrite mods higher in the order.

mods.cfg — the load-order file in Kenshi’s game data folder that records which mods are installed and the order the game loads them; KMM’s playsets are saved as separate .cfg files of the same shape.

.mod file — the compiled file that identifies a Kenshi mod in the game’s Mods menu; a missing or misplaced .mod file is what a “.mod file error” actually means — the mod failed to load.

Steam Workshop ID — the numeric ?id=NNNNN that identifies a Workshop mod and is used to subscribe to it; every Workshop mod in this guide is referenced by its ID.

Mod conflict — when two mods edit the same game data, the later-loaded one wins — e.g. never run Fish and Meat Industry with its superseded sibling Meat Production and Processing, or Radiant Vanilla Reborn Weapons with Radiant Asamarume Weapons (already integrated in v2.0).

“Later wins” — shorthand for Kenshi’s override rule: when two mods edit the same value, the one loaded later in the order wins.

Mod card — the styled box used throughout this guide to present one verified mod: a clickable name link, version, verified status, dependencies, impact and notes, with its URL as the verified source.